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SPORTS

Khaidem Chanu to lead India women's hockey team in Junior Asia Cup

FCRA Bill debate in LS on August 12

Rules will not apply with retrospective effect, says Mizoram CM after meeting home minister with church leaders

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The controversial FCRA amendment Bill will be taken up for discussion and passage in Parliament on August 12 but it will not come into effect retrospectively, Mizoram Chief Minister Lalduhoma said after meeting Union Home Minister Amit Shah. Lalduhoma and a delegation of church leaders from Mizoram conveyed their concerns to Shah over the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, which seeks to significantly tighten the oversight of foreign-funded organisations, proposing creation of a powerful new authority to seize and manage the assets of non-profits that lose their licence. “We have conveyed our apprehensions on the new FCRA Bill to the home minister. He assured us that the Bill will not come into effect retrospectively,” Lalduhoma told

Union Home Affairs Minister Amit Shah during the Monsoon session of Parliament in New Delhi on Thursday

reporters at the Parliament House complex. Asked whether the home minister indicated any date for discussion and passage of the FCRA amendment Bill in Parliament, he said Shah told him that the proposed legislation will be debated in the House on August 12. The Bill was introduced in Lok Sabha on March 25.

The Bill provides for a comprehensive framework for vesting, supervision, management and disposal of foreign contributions and assets in a designated author-

ity, including provisional and permanent vesting. The foreign contribution and the assets created out of foreign contribution of any person — whose certificate has been cancelled under Section 14; or who has surrendered the certificate under section 14A; or whose certificate has ceased under section 14B or any rules made under this Act — shall, from the date of such cancellation, surrender or cessation, vest provisionally in the designated authority in such manner as may be prescribed, the proposed, law said. If an individual fails to obtain a fresh certificate or gets their certificate renewed or restored within the period referred in the law, the foreign contribution and the assets created out of foreign contributions shall thereupon stand permanently vested in the designated authority, the Bill proposes.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Union Minister for Electronics and Information Technology, Ashwini Vaishnaw on Tuesday

MeitY unveils tougher rules for AI content

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Union Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) has suggested changes to the information technology rules for faster online content takedowns. If these changes take effect, social media platforms and other intermediaries will have to remove unlawful, AI-generated content within three hours of getting a valid Government or court order. The current deadline is 36-hours. The updated rules also require clear labels on AI-generated content and faster responses to complaints. These steps aim to tackle problems caused by deepfakes, AI-driven misinformation, and other types of synthetic media. In February 2026, MeitY announced changes to the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021. The new rules set up a formal process for handling Synthetically-Generated Information (SGI), including audio, visual, or audiovisual material made or

IF THE COMPLAINT INVOLVES NON-CONSENSUAL INTIMATE IMAGES, NUDITY OR IMPERSONATION, THE TAKE DOWN TIME IS 2 HOURS

changed by AI or algorithms to look real. The proposed changes shorten the time online platforms have to respond. If the complaint involves non-consensual intimate images, nudity or impersonation, the deadline is two hours. Platforms have to handle general complaints within seven days, down from 15, and urgent cases within 36 hours. They also need to label approved SGI so users can clearly spot synthetic content. When possible, permanent metadata or unique identifiers should be added to help trace content. Routine good-faith edits, accessibility enhancements, and certain educational or conceptual uses are excluded from the definition of SGI.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Meta faces second day of grilling

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Union Government has sought clarifications from Meta's visiting global team regarding the company's adherence to the laws of the land, pursuant to summons issued in connection with the recent temporary restriction of a Facebook post by the Prime Minister Narendra Modi, sources indicated on Thursday. Union IT minister, Ashwini Vaishnaw met Meta's global team on Thursday, sources

Meta delegation leave the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology office in New Delhi on Wednesday

said, adding that the ministry's discussions with technical teams will continue thereafter. Meta's team was grilled by the Government for the second consecutive days after PM's July 23 Facebook post was briefly restricted on the platform. Meta will also be questioned on its algorithms, whether its compliance mechanism has sufficient checks and balances, and whether its guardrails meet constitutional and legal requirements, Government sources said. According to Government sources, Vaishnaw had asked Meta point-blank on Wednesday whether the company accepted payments to promote content that could trigger public disorder.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

The Bystander

BJP deliberately lost bypolls - Akhilesh Yadav

MDR ON UPI GETS LS NOD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Lok Sabha on Thursday passed a Bill to amend the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007 that authorises the Government to permit banks and other service providers to levy charges on payments through Unified Payments Interface (UPI) and other notified electronic payment modes. The amendment passed by the House without discussion amid din seeks to remove the existing legal provision that prevents banks and payment service

Lok Sabha during the Monsoon session of Parliament, in New Delhi

providers from charging Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on notified electronic payment modes. While bankers and other stakeholders in the payment industry have been pressing for MDR on UPI, the Government has so far not moved in the matter. Some watchers have been expecting MDR to set in for UPI transactions above a certain value between a merchant and customer, and not in the case of peer-to-peer payments. “MDR applies only on the merchants and not on the end users/customers. It will support the banks and Fintech companies to invest more on infrastructure, innovation and security,” Union Minister of Finance, Nirmala Sitharaman clarified on X.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Govt reaches out to Congress on delimitation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Keen to secure Parliamentary approval for the delimitation and the women's reservation Bills, Union Minister for Parliamentary Affairs, Kiren Rijiju on Thursday held a telephonic conversation with Congress leader and the Leader of Opposition (LoP) in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi to seek support for the passage of the Bills. The latter, however, insisted on convening an all-party meeting on the proposed legislation, it was learnt. “I had a productive conversation with Rahul Gandhi. I have made a request on a few specific issues and also discussed other matters. We expect continuous communication and coordinated action with the Congress and other Opposition parties,” Rijiju told reporters in the Parliament House complex. The parliamentary affairs minister, however, did not give any commitment

LoP in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi in conversation with Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra in the Parliament complex on Thursday

on convening the all-party meeting on the Bill, the sources said. The Government is trying for a consensus on the women's reservation and delimitation Bill, they added. Sources said that attempts are being made by the floor managers of the Government for reintroduction of the

Bills, with some tweaks to the earlier Bills to allay apprehensions of the southern States. The Government is trying to reintroduce the Bill next week, with four working days of the Monsoon Session remaining before its closure on August 13.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Bombay HC convicts Tarun Tejpal for rape, awards 10-year jail term

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Panaji

Journalist Tarun Tejpal was convicted of rape and sentenced to 10 years of rigorous imprisonment by the Bombay High Court on Thursday in a 2013 case that the former magazine editor was acquitted in at the trial court five years ago. The HC termed the trial court's 2021 verdict perverse, noting that it fell for the notion that a sexual assault complainant must be a “perfect victim” and conduct herself in a certain way so as to appear credible. Tejpal, former editor-in-chief of *Tehelka*, was convicted

Tarun Tejpal

ed of raping a junior colleague inside a hotel elevator in 2013 during an event organised by the magazine in Goa. The 62-year-old journalist claimed that he was a political victim and would approach the Supreme Court to challenge his conviction. A bench of Justices Neela Gokhale and Amit Jamsandekar, while handing down the minimum sentence of ten years' rigorous imprisonment, noted that the incident took place 13 years ago and Tejpal had not committed any other criminal offence. The maximum punishment for rape is life imprisonment.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Protest is part of democracy, says Bhagwat

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat on Thursday said protest is a legitimate form of dialogue in a democracy and should be aimed at building consensus rather than creating divisions, comments coming in the backdrop of a recent stir by a fledgling pressure group on exam paper leaks. “Protest is also a way of dialogue. In a democracy, protest is a way of building consensus. Different views come together and a consensus evolves after discussion, he said, addressing a gathering of around 2,000 Gen Z and Gen Alpha members at India's International

RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat interacting with students during an event, in Mumbai on Thursday

Movement to Unite Nations (IIMUN) 15th anniversary event in Mumbai. “If, for various reasons, concerns are not heard through dialogue, people may turn to agitation. But the purpose of

all this is to build consensus, not to create divisions. The Gen Z grievances are genuine and I believe in their honesty,” he emphasised. Bhagwat noted the concerns being raised over

India's education system are genuine and batted for increasing spending on the key sector to 6 per cent of the GDP. “Education is not a commercial business; it should be structured in such a way that it is available for all. Society should also contribute to improving the status of education,” the RSS chief said. Bhagwat's interaction is being seen as the RSS' most significant outreach to Gen Z (born roughly 1997-2012) and Gen Alpha (2013-2025) since the Cockroach Janta Party's (CJP) protests over NEET paper leak culminated in Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation last month.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Ladakh opens India's first high-altitude safari for snow leopard spotting

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Wildlife enthusiasts and bird watchers get ready for a rendezvous with the snow leopard in the high-altitude regions of Ladakh. Lieutenant Governor (LG) Vinai Kumar Saxena has approved the introduction of wildlife safaris on popular snow-leopard and bird-watching trails in Ladakh's high-altitude regions, adding a new dimension to the Union Territory's vibrant ecotourism. This will be India's first high-altitude wildlife safari, offering visitors a rare guided opportunity to experience Ladakh's distinctive flora and

fauna. Ladakh is home to India's largest snow leopard population — 477 of the country's estimated 718 snow leopards. Ladakh also supports over 38 mammal species, 340 bird species and 1,800 vascular plant species that have drawn substantial tourist attraction over the years. The LG has directed the Forest Department to introduce guided jeep safari on the lines of popular National Parks like Kaziranga, Ranthambore and others, using specially designed open-back vehicles, to be operated by trained local drivers and guides. The objective behind intro-

Himalayan snow leopard

ducing guided safaris is to prevent incidents of illegal off-roading and disturbing wildlife, besides strengthening sustainable and responsible eco-friendly tourism and enhancing visitor experience. The decision was taken in the first governing body meeting of the newly constituted Snow Leopard and High-Altitude Nature (SHAN) Conservation Society, chaired by LG Saxena. The Lieutenant Governor has directed the Forest Department to explore the possible safari routes across Hemis National Park, Changthang and Karakoram Wildlife Sanctuaries, apart

from areas like Nubra, Zaskar, Sham, Kargil and Drass, that are known to have a sizable presence of elusive snow leopards and vivid avian diversity. It has further been decided that 20 local youth will be selected, trained in bird-watching, bird identification and bird-spotting skills and will be provided with equipment like binoculars. Besides, 10 bird-watching hides will be created at major hot-spots. According to a spokesman of the office of the Lieutenant Governor of Ladakh, “The SHAN Society, constituted by the Lieutenant Governor on June 16 this year, seeks to formulate a comprehensive

roadmap for community-led wildlife conservation, waste management and promoting plastic-free tourism, sustainable livelihood generation and responsible tourism across Ladakh”. SHAN Society envisages a unique model of environment conservation in Ladakh, wherein the Government alone will not be responsible for environment protection, but local communities will be made active partners in protecting Ladakh's fragile ecosystem and wildlife. This will instil a sense of custodianship among the people, while creating sustainable livelihood opportunities for them.

DDA launches digital system to monitor plantation drive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has launched a first-of-its-kind digital monitoring system to track its ongoing plantation drive in real time, with geo-tagged data, photographs and a public dashboard aimed at ensuring the survival of saplings.

The initiative, launched following directions from Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, will enable authorities to monitor plantation progress, identify delays and maintenance gaps, and record plant mortality for timely corrective action.

“For the first time, a plantation programme of this scale will be monitored through a dedicated mobile application integrated with a Plantation Monitoring Dashboard. Field officers, particularly Section Officers (Horticulture), will use the app to upload site-specific details, photographs and geo-tagged data,” the DDA said in a statement.



The information uploaded through the app will sync with a central dashboard, enabling real-time monitoring across divisions while flagging delays, maintenance gaps and plant mortality for prompt intervention.

“The initiative aims to ensure survival and sustained growth of saplings, rather than just meeting numerical targets,” the statement said.

A key feature of the programme is its emphasis on survival and sustained growth, rather than merely achieving numerical targets. Field-level responsibility has been clearly

assigned for watering, maintenance, protection, and monitoring. Plant mortality will be recorded through the system and replacement plantation will be undertaken wherever required.

According to officials, plant mortality will be recorded in the system and replacement plantation will be carried out wherever required.

To enhance transparency, the DDA will also engage an independent third-party authority to verify and assess plantation survival. Its findings will help identify areas requiring additional maintenance or

corrective measures.

Officials said more than 50 per cent of the target to plant 23 lakh indigenous saplings has already been achieved in less than a month.

The Plantation Monitoring Dashboard, accessible on the DDA's official website, will provide park-wise information, including details of species planted, latitude and longitude coordinates, and field updates for public viewing.

“The portal also showcases photographs from joint drives in which 13,750 people participated, including members from 118 Resident Welfare Associations, 18 religious organisations, 31 government, paramilitary, police and NGO bodies, 24 schools, and 11 institutes,” the DDA said.

The authority said that by combining technology, field accountability, public disclosure, community participation and independent assessment, the plantation drive would become trackable, measurable and outcome-oriented.

CM inaugurates STEM Innovation Lab at Pitampura Govt school

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday inaugurated a Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) Innovation Lab at Sarvodaya Vidyalaya in Pitampura. The lab was developed with support from the Shikhar Dhawan Foundation, HMD India, and Da One Group, with cricketer and Da One Group Chairman Shikhar Dhawan present at the event alongside Education Department officials, teachers, and students.

The Chief Minister said the STEM Innovation Lab is not just a laboratory but the beginning of a new era of innovation and scientific thinking for Delhi's students. She said science, technology, engineering, and mathematics are not merely academic subjects but the foundation of the economy of the future and of nation-building.

She said the Delhi Government aims to equip every government school



with modern facilities, digital technology, and innovation-driven learning resources so that students are prepared for future challenges. Rather than limiting students to textbook learning, the need of the hour is hands-on, experiment-based education, creative thinking, and problem-solving skills, she said.

The Chief Minister said the lab will encourage students to work on new ideas, develop a scientific outlook, and find solutions to real-life problems. She said students in government schools today will become tomorrow's scientists, engineers, innovators, startup founders, and nation-

builders, and the government's goal is to ensure every child has equal access to modern resources and quality education.

She expressed gratitude to the Shikhar Dhawan Foundation, HMD India, and Da One Group for their support and said partnerships between the government and private sector can serve as a powerful catalyst for positive change in education. She expressed hope that similar collaborations would further strengthen Delhi's education system.

The inauguration is part of a broader push by the Delhi government to upgrade infrastructure in government schools.

Speeding truck mows down herd of cow on Faridabad road

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Faridabad

A speeding truck allegedly ran over around 10 cows sitting by a road in Sector 18 here early Thursday, killing six and inflicting severe injuries to the others, police said. Following the incident, infuriated locals allegedly set the truck on fire and mobbed the driver. Police and fire brigade teams arrived at the scene and brought the situation under control.



The mob later handed over the truck driver to police.

An FIR has been registered at Old Police Station, and the accused driver — identified as Shahid (50), a resident of Nuh district — has been arrested, police said.

According to eyewitnesses, the cows were sitting along the Old Road in Sector 18 when the speeding truck ran over them. Chaos and cries of distress erupted at the scene. Several cows were writhing in pain on the road, while six died on the spot.

Upon learning of the incident, a large number of locals and cow vigilantes rushed to the site. Incensed, the crowd set the truck on fire, which was soon engulfed in flames. The mob also caught the accused driver.

After getting information, a police team arrived at the scene and attempted to pacify the crowd. Subsequently, a fire tender reached the spot, and the fire was brought under control, police said.

Govt mulls bus service to Noida airport

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Noida

To boost footfall at the Noida International Airport (NIA) in Jewar, the Delhi government is planning to launch public buses to ensure seamless connectivity for passengers. The Noida International Airport in the national capital region (NCR) began passenger flight operations almost a month ago.

“We plan to start the bus service right upto the Jewar airport, like private vehicles are allowed. A Reciprocal Transport Agreement will be signed soon between Delhi and Uttar Pradesh state transport authorities in this



regard,” an official said.

The government is planning is to operate several buses from the Anand Vihar and Kashmere Gate interstate bus terminals to Jewar airport, he added.

“A proposal is ready. After the two authorities finalise the details of the agreement,

the services will start. This initiative is part of the broader effort by the state government to strengthen public transport infrastructure and expand interstate mobility,” the official said.

Earlier this year, the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) had approved a plan to introduce 100 electric interstate buses on 17 routes.

The DTC has already commenced operations of electric buses on key routes including Delhi-Baraut (Uttar Pradesh), Delhi-Sonapat (Haryana), Delhi-Dharuhera (Haryana), and Delhi-Panipat (Haryana), improving connectivity between Delhi and neighbouring regions.

MCD to sign MoU with multinational bank for tech-driven parking fee collection

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) will next week sign a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with a multinational bank to introduce a technology-driven parking fee collection system. The system, aimed at preventing overcharging by linking point-of-sale (POS) machines directly to the civic body's central server, will be rolled out on a pilot basis at five parking sites in the first phase and is part of the MCD's plan to move

towards cashless parking fee collection, a senior official said.

Under the proposed arrangement, the MCD will provide POS machines to parking contractors instead of allowing them to use their own devices.

The machines will be integrated with the MCD's central server, enabling parking slips to be generated automatically based on the duration for which a vehicle remains parked.

A senior Remunerative Project Cell (RP Cell) official said the system would calcu-



late parking charges at the notified rate of Rs 20 per hour and generate receipts directly from the MCD server, leaving little scope for contractors to overcharge motorists.

“The idea is to eliminate complaints of overcharging and bring greater trans-

parency to parking fee collection. Since every receipt will be generated through the MCD server, contractors will not be able to demand excess payment,” the official said. The civic body also plans to introduce a “No Parking Slip, No Payment” system under which motorists will pay only against a digitally generated receipt issued through the authorised POS machine.

Officials said the system would be expanded to all MCD-managed parking sites across Delhi if the pilot project proves successful.



INDRAPRASTHA POWER GENERATION CO. LTD. & PRAGATI POWER CORPORATION LIMITED

(Govt. of NCT of Delhi Undertakings)

Corporate Identity No. (CIN)-IPGCL- U40103DL20001SGC111530

Corporate Identity No. (Cin)-PPCL U74899DL20001SGC109135

(ISO 9001-2008. 14001- 2007,18001-2007 Certified)

ED(C&M), PRAGATI Power Station-I, I.P. Estate, Ring Road, New Delhi-110002.

TEL: 011-23370541, FAX No. 011 23379164

NIT No. 03/2026-27

TENDERING FOR ONLINE BIDDING

Date: 30/06/2026

Offers are invited in two parts system on e-tendering on the portal of Delhi Govt, at <https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> , for the below items with tender closing time at 11.00 hrs. on bid submission date: -

Tender ID & Description	T-Value (Rs.)
01 2026 IPGCL 293674 Procurement of 01 multipurpose Diesel, BS VI Compliance Fire Tender at PPS-III Bawana	1,34,66,666.00
02 2026 IPGCL 293250 Procurement of four set of Blended Media India Air Filters (F9 AS PER. en779:2012 OR MERV 15AS PER ASHRAE 52.2:2012 STANDARD) for 9 Fa Gas Turbines installed at PPS-III, Bawana	2,80,60,800.00

Corrigendum/Retender

01 2025 IPGCL 287686_1 Paving Work at different location of unpaved area at PPS-III Bawana	1,20,72,261.33
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Note: 1) Tender Issue Date & EMD details: - Please visit IPGCL-PPCL website (www.ipgcl-ppcl.gov.in)

2) Bid Submission End Date & Bid Opening Date : As per IPGCL-PPCL website and Delhi Govt e-portal

3) No Corrigendum/addendum/modification for tender value up to Rs 50.00 Lacs will be advertised in newspaper and bidders are requested to regularly visit IPGCL-PPCL website as well as Delhi Government E-procurement site for getting themselves updated.

DTP/Shabdarth/Classified/00168/26-27



MODI RUBBER LIMITED

CIN: L25199UP1971PLC003392

Registered Office: Modinagar - 201204; Dist. Ghaziabad, (U.P.)

Corporate Office: 4-7C, DDA Shopping Centre, New Friends Colony, New Delhi-110025; Website: www.modirubberlimited.com

Email: investors@modigroup.net; Phone: + 91-11-47107398

NOTICE

Pursuant to regulation 29 of SEBI (LODR) 2015, Notice is hereby given that a 314th Meeting of the Board of Directors of the Company is scheduled to be held on Friday on 14th day of August, 2026 at 03.00 PM at Corporate Office: 4-7/C, DDA Shopping Centre, 4th Floor, New Friends Colony, New Delhi-110025 to inter-alia approve the following:

- Un-Audited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Statements of the Company for the period ended on June 30, 2026.
- To fix the Date, Time and Venue for convening the 53rd Annual General Meeting.
- To consider and approve Directors Report, Corporate Governance Report, Management Discussion Analysis Report and Secretarial Audit Report for the financial year 2025-26.
- Review of Financial Statements of WOS/JVC and Associates Companies for the Quarter ended 30th June 2026.
- Alteration of the Objects Clause of the Memorandum of Association.

For Modi Rubber Limited

Sd/-

(S K Bajpai)

Head - Legal & Co. Secretary

Place : New Delhi

Date : 06.08.2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

General Public is hereby informed that State Environment Impact Assessment Authority (SEIAA), Haryana, Bays No. 55-58, Paryatan Bhawan, Sector-2, Panchkula, Haryana vide EC Identification No. EC26C3801HR5612851N dated 05.08.2026 has accorded the "Environment Clearance" to M/s. Boxacres Developers Pvt. Ltd, Forsythia Propbuild Pvt. Ltd. in collaboration with M/s. Boxacres Developers Pvt. Ltd. having its office at 10th Floor, Tower-2, M3M IFC, Sector 66, Gurugram, Haryana-122101 for Proposed Retirement Housing Project under Retirement Housing Policy dated 04.11.2024 located in the revenue estate of Village Naurangpur, Sector-79, Gurugram - Manesar Urban Complex, Haryana

General Public is further informed that copy of said Environment Clearance Letter is available in the office of Haryana State Pollution Control Board, Panchkula and State Environment Impact Assessment Authority (SEIAA), Panchkula, Haryana and also available at website of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change <https://parivesh.nic.in/>.

Place: Gurugram
Dated: 07.08.2026

M/s. Boxacres Developers Pvt. Ltd., Forsythia Propbuild Pvt. Ltd. in collaboration with M/s. Boxacres Developers Pvt. Ltd.
Office at 10th Floor, Tower-2, M3M IFC, Sector 66, Gurugram, Haryana-122101



Regional Office: Netaji Marg, Nr. Mithakhali Six Roads, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-6. Phone: + 91-79-2642171-75

Demand Notice to Borrowers

The under mentioned account turned into N.P.A and demand notice is issued by Bandhan Bank Ltd. to the following borrower(s), under sec.13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (The Act), 2002 which was returned unserved. Hence, this notice is issued to you all and public at large through publication.

Name of borrower(s), and Loan Account No.	Description of mortgaged property (Secured Asset)	Date of Demand Notice/Date of NPA	O/S Amount as on Date of Demand Notice	Date of Pasting of Notice
Mr. Anil Kumar Yadav Mrs. Mira Yadav 20003310000064	All That Piece or Parcel of Admeasuring the Land Area As 58.52 Sq Mtr and Super Built Up Area As 58.52 Sq Mtr Situated at Kharsa No-149/1, New Shanti Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh -201009 Owned by Mrs. Mira Yadav and Same Bounded as Under: North: Road 15 Feet Wide, East: Other Plot, West: Other Plot, South: Other Plot	July 29, 2025/ July 04, 2025	Rs.6,90,452.88	July 24, 2026

Demand made against you through this notice to repay to the Bank dues mentioned against your name with interest, costs and charges within 60 days from the date hereof, failing which the Bank will further proceed to take steps u/s.13(4) of the SARFAESI Act. The borrowers'/mortgagors' attention is invited to the provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Place: Ghaziabad

Date: August 07, 2026

Sd/-

Authorized Officer,

BANDHAN INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

PUBLIC NOTICE

LOSS OF ORIGINAL RBI CERTIFICATE OF REGISTRATION

Notice is hereby given that the original Certificate of Registration (CoR) issued by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) in favour of M/s Manvi Investment Private Limited having its registered office at (RPS Centre Block-EPGH 2LOCAL SHOPPING CENTRE GK II, NEW DELHI, India, 110048 bearing COR No : 14.00912, issued on 30/05/1998 has been lost/misplaced and despite diligent search, the same could not be traced.

The matter has been reported to the concerned Police Station vide LR No 477036/2026 dated 24/07/2026.

Any person having possession of or claiming any right, title or interest in the aforesaid Certificate of Registration is requested to inform the undersigned or the Reserve Bank of India within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. If no claim is received within the stipulated period, the Company shall proceed with its application to the Reserve Bank of India for issuance of a Duplicate Certificate of Registration, and any claim thereafter shall not be entertained.

For Manvi Investment Private Limited

Authorised Signatory

Saurabh Singhal

Director

Place : New Delhi

Date : 06/08/2026

Din No : 01046335

PUBLIC NOTICE

Reg. Entire Third floor, with roof rights (the said floor), built on Property Bearing No. 65, in Block-A, area measuring 198.33 Sq. Yds. (165.804 Sq. Mtrs), situated in the layout plan of C.P.W.D. Govt. Servants Co-operative Housing Building Society Ltd., known as Laxmi Vihar, Pitampura, Delhi; Hereinafter referred to as "said property".

Be it known to all concerned that our clients, Mr. Deepak Taneja, Mrs. Shivangini Taneja, and Mrs. CL ZINCO PVT. LTD. (hereinafter collectively referred to as the "Purchasers"), intend to purchase the said floor from Mr. Vikas Nayyar (hereinafter referred to as the "Seller"). In this connection, the Seller has represented to the Purchasers that he is the absolute owner of the said floor by virtue of a Partition Deed dated 19.01.2026 executed amongst Mr. Vishwas Nayyar, Mrs. Pervesh Nayyar, and Mr. Vikas Nayyar. The said Partition Deed is duly registered as Document No. 2026/1561/1160, Volume No. 16889, Pages 63 to 86, on 20.01.2026. The Seller has further represented that, prior to the execution of the said Partition Deed, the said floor was owned by Late Mr. Indar Nath Nayyar by virtue of a Conveyance Deed registered as Document No. 10021 dated 22.06.1995. Upon the demise of Late Mr. Indar Nath Nayyar, the said floor was inherited by his legal heirs, namely: (i) Mrs. Pervesh Nayyar (wife), (ii) Mr. Vikas Nayyar (son), and (iii) Mr. Vishwas Nayyar (son). The seller has also informed the purchasers that the said floor is not mortgaged anywhere and there is no charge or dispute or any litigation pending regarding the said floor.

Any person including Banks, Financial Institutions, relatives having any claim, right, title or any interest of any nature whatsoever into or upon the aforesaid floor is hereby called upon to make the same known, in writing, with documentary evidence, by Registered AD Post, to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below within 07 (seven) days of publication of this notice and in the event of no response having been received to the notice, the title of the seller to the said floor shall be deemed to be clear of any charge or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever and any subsequent claim shall not bind our clients/Purchaser, in any manner whatsoever.

Shivkant Arora, Advocate

M/s Intelective Law Offices

A-74, LCF, Defence Colony,

New Delhi-110024

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client (i.e. SMFG India Credit Co. Ltd.) that Mr. Karanveer Lal is claiming to be the owner of Built-up Basement, Second Floor Third Floor with roof rights, and administering 80 sq yds of Property bearing No.1A,206A Part of Kharsa No.415, 1A,2561 Part of Kharsa No.415, 1A,256 Part of Kharsa No.414, total administering 329 sq. yds, situated at Gali No.1, Taghlabad Eastn, New Delhi-110019, vide Regd. Gift Deed dated 11.07.2026 executed by Mr. Javed Lal Gour in favour of Mr. Karanveer Lal, duly regd. as Doc No. 2026/1046491, Volume No. 2026/1046491, Pages 109-120, 58-South Eastn-Mall on 30.07.2026. Whereas, Mr. Javed Lal Gour was appointed attorney by Mr. Ramesh Chander Gupta, vide notary note No. 48.02.07.2026 & Mr. Ramesh Chander Gupta acquired interest in the said property vide notarized GATs, ATS & Will dt. 17.03.1980 executed by Mr. Ram. Phil. All persons are hereby informed that above mentioned Owner wants to mortgage the said property & intends to obtain a loan from our client (i.e. SMFG India Credit Co. Ltd.) against the said property, if anybody has any objection against the ownership of the said property or the said property, its mortgage/sale/gift, or any other objections, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 15 days of the present.

Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)

202, Ind. Flr. 23, Shivaji Marg, Modt Nagar, New Delhi-110015

Legal@kandlegal.com

Ph: 011-41112527-28

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Mr. Abdul Kalam Azad, S/o Late Abdul Salam, R/o H-120, Batia House, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, hereby disown and debar my son Mohammad Farhan and my daughter-in-law Samreen from all my movable and immovable properties due to their conduct. They shall have no right, title, claim or interest in any of my properties. Any person dealing with them shall do so at his/her own risk. I shall not be responsible for any of their acts or liabilities.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Re: Second Floor & Third Floor with common roof/terrace rights, Northern Front Side Portion of (the said floor) Built-up Property Bearing Plot No. G-64, area measuring 134.4 sq. yds. i.e. 112.38 sq. mtrs., Situated in the revenue estate of Village Basai Darapur, Delhi State Delhi, area abadi known as Colony Mansarovar Garden, New Delhi-110015; hereinafter referred to as "said property".

NOTICE is hereby given to general public that our clients, Mr. Virender Kumar Sharma (hereinafter called the "owner") is the absolute owner of the said floor. It has been further informed that initially Mrs. Raksha Devi owned the said property vide Partition Deed Dated 17.05.2002 and thereafter Mrs. Raksha Devi expired leaving behind Legal Heirs namely Mr. Ravinder Kumar Sharma (Son) & (2) Virender Kumar Sharma (Son). And finally Mr. Ravinder Kumar Sharma relinquishes his share of the said floor of the said property in favour of Mr. Virender Kumar Sharma vide Relinquishment Deed dated 06.08.2025, the said deed duly registered as Document No. 2025/22/110264. Hence, Mr. Virender Kumar Sharma became the owner of the said floor. The said owner has also informed that the said floor is not mortgage anywhere and there is no dispute or any litigation pending upon the said floor.

Any person including Banks, Financial Institutions, relatives having any claim, right, title or any interest of any nature whatsoever into or upon the said floor is hereby called upon to make the same known, in writing, with documentary evidence, by Registered AD Post, to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below within 07 days of publication of this notice and in the event of no response having been received to the notice, the title of the owner in respect of the said property shall be deemed to be clear of any charge or encumbrance of any nature whatsoever and any subsequent claim shall not bind our client/owner, in any manner whatsoever.

Shivkant Arora, Advocate

For M/s Intelective Law Offices

A-74, LCF, Defence Colony,

New Delhi-110024

PUBLIC NOTICE

The general public is hereby informed that residential plot P-16, Sector 11, Noida, Gautam Buddh Nagar, U. P. (Hereinafter, the said plot) was transferred to Shri. Amulya Ratan Bhattacharyya S/o Ram. J. Bhattacharyya R/o P-16, Sector 11, Noida - 201301 vide Noida Authority Transfer Memo dated 3-2-1994 and transfer-deed registered at sub-registrar (1) Noida on 9-2-1994.

The forenamed transferee, who expired on 24-04-1998, willed the house built on the said plot to his son Bimal Kumar Bhattacharyya and daughter may Maya Bhattacharyya W/o Paritosh Bhattacharyya vide first-and-last wills-and-testaments registered in Bahi 3, Zild 153, Page 38, No. 235-236 at sub-registrar (2) Noida on 28-6-1994.

The said plot is going to be transferred to the forenamed transferee's heirs who are: 1. Tapan Kumar Bhattacharyya 2. Madhumita Banerjee (Both S/D/o late Paritosh Bhattacharyya) 3. Shantanu Bhattacharyya 4. Alanu Bhattacharyya (Both S/D/o late Bimal Kumar Bhattacharyya).

Anyone objecting to the transfer of the said plot to the forenamed heirs may contact Noida Authority (Residential Plots), Sector 6, Noida within 30 days after this publication. Any objection thereafter would not be entertained.

Tapan Kumar Bhattacharyya

(Co-heir)

Date: 07.08.2026

Place: Noida



SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.

Corporate Off.: 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-BLOCK, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051.

Regd. Off.: Commercial Zone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallia Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

POSSESSION NOTICE FOR IMMOVABLE PROPERTY [Appendix IV] Rule 8(1)

WHEREAS the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. a Housing Finance Company (duly registered with National Housing Bank (Fully Owned by RBI)) (hereinafter referred to as "SMHFC") under Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002), and in exercise of the powers conferred under Section 13(2) of the said Act calling upon you being the borrowers (names mentioned below) to repay the amount mentioned in the said notice and interest thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers mentioned herein below having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrowers mentioned herein below and to the public in general that the undersigned has Taken Possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of the said Act with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. The borrowers mentioned here in above in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with said property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of "SMHFC" for an amount as mentioned herein under and interest thereon.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of Secured Assets (Immovable Property)	Demand Notice Date & Amt.	Date of Possession
1	LAN - 605438311414838 1. Brahm Singh S/o. Shri Ram 2. Manju Baljeet	Third Floor With Roof / Terrace Right of Built Up Property Bearing No. 2 Area Measuring 50 Sq. Yards i. e. 41.81 Sq. Mtr. of out Of Kharsa No. 105/16 Situated In The Area Of Village : Palam Delhi State Delhi Colony Known as Raja Puri In Block-F Uttam Nagar-110 059. Boundaries - East : Plot No. 1; West : Other Plot; North : Road 20 Ft., South : Road 18 Ft.	22.05.2026 Rs. 15,31,593.89 (Rs. FIFTY-LEEN Lakh Thirty One Thousand Five Hundred Ninety Three & Paise Eighty Nine Only) along with interest as on 22.05.2026	01.08.2026
2	LAN - 609139211797298 1. Sonu Mukhtyar Singh S/o. Mukhtyar Singh 2. Ritu Kaur C/o. Sonu Singh	Built Up Property Bearing No. A-4/A Area Measuring 41.80 Sq. Meters i. e. 50 Sq. Yards Third Floor With Roof Rights Out of Kharsa No. 283/2 Situated At Village Ghonda Gujran Khadar In The Abadi of A Block Gali No. 4 Bhajanpura Illaga Shahadara, Delhi-110 053 Boundaries - East : Property of Others; West : Property No. A-4/4; North : Gali 10 Ft. Wide; South : Property of Others.	22.05.2026 Rs. 22,57,899.14 (Rs. Twenty Two Lakh Fifty Seven Thousand Eight Hundred Ninety Nine & Paise Fourteen Only) along with interest as on 22.05.2026	01.08.2026
3	LAN - 609139212148815 1. Lovekush Pal S/o. Ram Prakash 2. Laxmi Baghel C/o. Lovekush Pal	Property Area Measuring 59.80 Sq. Yards i. e. 50 Sq. Meter Property Bearing No. 83 Old Plot No. 38, 3 rd Floor With Roof / Terrace Rights Out of Kharsa No. 550 Situated At Village Sikanderpur In The Abadi Of Bhagwanpur Khara Gali No. 1 Chakradelok Colony Shahdara, Delhi-110 093. Boundaries - East : Remaining Portion; West : Plot No. 36 & 37; North : Remaining Portion; South : 20 Ft. Wide and As Per Site / Actual East : Property of Mrs. Neha; West : Property Of Mr. Pawar; North : Other Property; South : 20 Ft. Wide.	22.05.2026 Rs. 30,06,126.60 (Rs. Thirty Lakh Six Thousand One Hundred Twenty Six & Paise Sixty Only) along with interest as on 22.05.2026	01.08.2026
4	LAN - 605438011859057 1. Ankit Kumar S/o. Vikram Singh 2. Shashi Kala W/o. Ankit Kumar	Flat On Ground Floor Without Roof Right Built On Plot No. C-292 Area Measuring 50 Sq Meter Comprising Kharsa No. 145 Situated At Panchawati Colony, Block-C In Village Mahma Sarai URF Kot Pargana Loni Tehsil & Dist. Ghaziabad. Boundaries - East : Other House; West : Road 20 Ft., North : Other Property; South : Other Property.	22.05.2026 Rs. 23,24,073/- (Rs. Twenty Three Lakh Twenty Four Thousand Seventy Three Only) along with interest as on 22.05.2026	01.08.2026

Place : Delhi / Ghaziabad

Date : 01.08.2026

Sd/-

Authorized Officer,

SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

Monsoon mayhem: Delhi battles waterlogging, traffic chaos

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Torrential rain battered Delhi on Thursday, inundating roads, disrupting traffic across the city and leaving commuters stranded for hours on several key stretches, as civic agencies attempted to attend to complaints regarding traffic congestion, waterlogging and fallen trees. With heavy rainfall, Thursday became Delhi's wettest day of August so far this year, offering respite from the humidity.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Lodi Road recorded the highest rainfall between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm at 60.4 mm, followed by Safdarjung at 56.0 mm, Ridge at 54.4 mm, Ayanagar at 22.3 mm and Palam at 14.6 mm. The cumulative rainfall recorded since 8.30 am stood at 43.8 mm at Lodi Road, 25.2 mm at Palam, 18.7 mm at Safdarjung, 17.2 mm at Ridge and

14.2 mm at Ayanagar, the IMD said. Sangam Vihar was among the worst-affected areas, with roads submerged and traffic movement severely disrupted. Waterlogging was also reported from Sainik Farms, Shastri Park, Rohtak Road, Tughlaqabad, near the Red Fort and parts of ITO, where inundated roads brought vehicles to a crawl.

Heavy congestion was reported from several key arterial roads including Aruna Asaf Ali Marg, Shaheed Jeet Singh Marg, Ber Sarai, the JNU Gate-Jia Sarai stretch, NH-48 between Dhaula Kuan and Rajokri flyover towards Gurugram, MB Road, Kalindi Kunj, Najafgarh, Rajdhani Park-Mundka, ITO-Laxmi Nagar, Akshardham, the CWG Village-Nizamuddin Bridge-Sarai Kale Khan corridor, and the Delhi-Dehradun expressway.

Commuters took to social media to express anguish over traffic snarls, with several saying journeys that usually take a few



(Left) Cycle-rickshaw pullers wade through waterlogged lanes after heavy rain disrupted movement across the area in Sadar Bazar; (right) Heavy traffic congestion seen at the ITO intersection following rainfall in New Delhi



PANKAJ KUMAR

International Airport, prompting major airlines to advise passengers to leave early for the airport in view of slow-moving traffic due to heavy rain and waterlogging in parts of the city. According to commuters, the rain also affected traffic at Kalindi Kunj, where vehicles were seen moving slowly amid waterlogged stretches.

Civic agencies remained engaged in clearing waterlogged stretches and removing fallen trees. According to officials, the Public Works Department (PWD) received around 30 complaints related to waterlogging, most of which were resolved within an hour. It also received 10 complaints of fallen trees, and clearance work is underway.

Major traffic congestions and waterlogging were reported from Defence Colony, Subroto Park, IGNOU Road, Sainik Farms, Mathura Road and Chawla, officials said.

Over 1,500 police personnel deployed in northeast Delhi for Kanwar Yatra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 1,500 police personnel, along with contingents of the Central Armed Police Force (CAPF), have been deployed across northeast Delhi as part of security measures in view of the ongoing Kanwar Yatra, an officer said on Thursday.

The annual pilgrimage, which began July 30 with the ushering in of the month of Shraavan, will conclude August 11 on the occasion of Shraavan Shivaratri, when devotees offer holy Ganga water at Shiva temples.

"A large number of Kanwariyas from Uttar Pradesh pass through northeast Delhi en route to Haryana and Rajasthan, making the district one of the key transit corridors for the yatra," a senior police officer said.



The officer said comprehensive law and order, security and traffic measures have been put in place to ensure smooth and peaceful movement of devotees. The district, which shares a border with Uttar Pradesh, has six permanent border pickets and nine motorable entry points through which Kanwariyas enter Delhi.

Police said 78 Kanwar camps have been set up in

the district, of which 31 are fully operational while the remaining are being prepared for devotees.

"Senior officers will monitor deployment and security measures throughout the pilgrimage period. Four sub-control rooms have also been established at Y-Point Dharampura, Maujpur Chowk, Khajuri Khas Chowk and near Gokalpuri T-Point to provide round-the-clock

assistance and coordinate emergency response," the officer said.

According to police, a total of 1,533 personnel have been deployed, including four assistant commissioners, 40 inspectors, 262 sub-inspectors and assistant sub-inspectors, 1,145 constables and head constables, and 81 women personnel.

An additional 250 CAPF personnel have been deployed in two shifts to assist in maintaining security and law and order.

The police have also deployed 27 PCR vans, five Prakhari vehicles and 107 motorcycles for patrolling along Kanwar yatra routes. Authorities have directed Kanwar camp organisers to install CCTV cameras and erect 'machans' (watch towers) to strengthen surveillance.

DU implements ₹20 lakh group insurance for employees

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Delhi University has implemented a Group Insurance Scheme with the Life Insurance Corporation of India providing ₹20 lakh death relief coverage to employees during service. The amount is payable to nominees upon death.

The scheme was implemented after DU Executive Council member Aman Kumar raised the issue of insurance disparity at the May 2025 Executive Council meeting and formally demanded the reinstatement of coverage for all teaching staff, irrespective of their date of appointment.

A circular dated August 5, 2026, issued by the Joint Registrar of Colleges through College Branch-III, has informed Principals, Directors, and Provosts of all colleges, institutions, and hostels of the University of

Delhi about the scheme's implementation. The circular further directs all colleges to coordinate directly with LIC of India to implement a similar scheme for their own non-teaching staff, both permanent and contractual, and teaching staff, without any liability on the University.

Under the scheme implemented by DU vide Notification dated October 16, 2025, employees pay a monthly contribution of ₹500 plus GST. The coverage of ₹20 lakh is payable to the nominee in the event of an employee's death during service. The circular specifies that there is no survival benefit, meaning the amount is payable only to eligible family members or the nominee in case of death in service, not upon retirement or resignation.

Aman Kumar, Executive Council and Court Member, University of Delhi, said he had exclusively raised the



issue and pushed for its implementation. "I raised this issue and got it implemented in DU and colleges," he said.

Kumar had submitted a formal note to Executive Council Meeting No 1275 on May 23, 2025, expressing concern over the continued absence of group insurance coverage for teaching faculty appointed in Delhi University and its constituent colleges after October 2013.

The Group Insurance Scheme, managed by LIC under Policy No 46796, had been discontinued for new entrants from October 2013,

resulting in teachers appointed before that date retaining coverage while those appointed after had none, despite doing the same work in the same institutions.

Kumar's note pointed out that the discontinuation had created a serious disparity among faculty members and deprived many of a critical element of social security. He noted that the importance of such coverage had become especially evident during unforeseen crises, citing the COVID-19 pandemic during which several members of the DU teaching community died, leaving families without insurance support.

The original scheme under Policy No 46796 provided Category A teaching faculty with a sum insured of ₹8 lakh against a monthly contribution of ₹800. In the event of natural death, the nominee received the sum insured along with a guaranteed savings amount.

NHAI directed to resolve recurring waterlogging issues along NH 24, says PWD Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Thursday directed NHAI to raise the road level to resolve recurring waterlogging problems on NH 24.

Heading the 'UT Level Coordination Committee' on the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) and Delhi government issues, several directions were given, including waterlogging at Mahipalpur T-Point.

The committee undertook a detailed review of recurring waterlogging on NH-24, particularly at the Patparganj and Pandav Nagar underpasses.

"Vulnerable locations including Nausena Bhawan, Thal Sena Bhawan, Mahipalpur T-Point and the R&R Hospital underpass were also reviewed. PWD and NHAI were directed to implement permanent engineering solutions. PWD has already completed the desilting of the concerned drain on NH-24, while NHAI has been directed to raise the road level to ensure a permanent solution to the waterlogging



issue," Singh said.

Effective coordination among all departments is essential for infrastructure development. Clear responsibilities and timelines have been assigned to every agency. Our priority is to eliminate inter-departmental bottlenecks, he added.

The minister has also directed NHAI to submit detailed technical reports on recurring waterlogging at the Mahipalpur flyover and the Parade Road underpass.

"NHAI consultants were directed to submit detailed technical reports to facilitate permanent engineering interventions. All agencies were also

instructed to jointly address drainage and sewer-related issues," he added.

The meeting also reviewed progress on the Andheria Mor-NH-48 Corridor, utility shifting for the Rangpuri Bypass Tunnel, the Rohtak Road Corridor, service roads and drainage infrastructure. "BSES was directed to complete the remaining technical formalities on priority, while all concerned departments were instructed to expedite pending approvals and utility shifting to keep project timelines on track," Singh further said.

The meeting also discussed traffic congestion at Delhi's border entry points caused by MCD toll plazas.

"NHAI and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi were directed to jointly address operational bottlenecks and take coordinated measures to ensure smoother movement of traffic entering the national capital," he added.

The minister also directed close coordination with the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) to expedite pending land-related issues concerning important National Highway projects.

ASI declares Purana Qila bastion critical and unsafe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A northern bastion of the 16th-century Purana Qila here has developed deep structural cracks, its condition ever-deteriorating owing to monsoon spells, with the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) declaring the part 'critical and unsafe', and initiating restoration works.

The affected structure, identified as North-West Bastion No. 3, overlooks the fort's artificial lake. Long cracks have become visible along its stone walls and floor, while fresh debris can be seen scattered inside and outside, indicating continuous structural deterioration, the ASI said.

The damaged bastion has been covered with tarpaulin to prevent rainwater seepage. Temporary scaffolding has been erected near the structure, with access to the affected portion now restricted.

All approaches leading to the damaged bastion have



been barricaded as a precaution. Sabhyata Foundation - the NGO entrusted with the management of Purana Qila -- has been instructed to ensure visitors do not enter the restricted area and all safety measures remain in place.

According to the ASI, the emergency conservation and restoration of the bastion was approved by the competent authority on August 3. The tender process and other formalities are currently underway before restoration begins.

"The situation is being closely monitored, and all necessary precautionary measures have been taken to safeguard both the monument and the visiting public until the conservation work is taken up," the ASI shared.

The agency said the bastion has been assessed as "critical and unsafe" because of continuous heavy rainfall and progressive deterioration of masonry.

It said the entire exposed surface has been covered with tarpaulin to minimise further water damage during

the monsoon.

The ASI said geologists, structural engineers and other experts are assisting in assessing the causes behind the recurring structural distress. Their findings will help determine appropriate scientific conservation measures before restoration work is undertaken.

The bastion has been under scrutiny ever since a portion of its masonry collapsed in August last year. Since then, visible cracks have continued to widen across walls and flooring, raising concerns over the condition of the structure.

Purana Qila, one of Delhi's oldest surviving forts, was built by Humayun and later strengthened by Sher Shah Suri during the 16th century.

Spread over nearly 1.5 km, the monument houses important structures such as the Qila-i-Kuhna Mosque and the Sher Mandal. It remains one of Delhi's most visited protected monuments, making the preservation of its historic bastions a conservation priority.



दिल्ली सरकार



Delhi Tourism



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

तीज महोत्सव 2026

दिल्ली सरकार द्वारा दिल्ली की बहनों के लिए विशेष आयोजन

आयोजन स्थल



08-09
अगस्त 2026



दिल्ली हाट, आई.एन.ए
दिल्ली हाट, पीतमपुरा



सुबह 11:30 बजे से
रात्रि 8:30 बजे तक

मुख्य आकर्षण

मेहंदी प्रतियोगिता, बिंदी प्रतियोगिता - 8 अगस्त, 2026

रंगोली प्रतियोगिता, मिस तीज 2026 - 9 अगस्त, 2026

प्रश्नोत्तरी, म्यूजिकल चेयर, सांस्कृतिक कार्यक्रम, स्लोगन लेखन, महिलाओं हेतु तीज क्विज प्रतियोगिता, रंगारंग कार्यक्रम

सभी 2 दिन

DIP/Shabdarth/Display/063/26-27

IN FOCUS



Police personnel stand near the Simli-Gwaldam National Highway blocked by debris following a landslide near Amsaud, as earthmoving machines clear the road in Chamoli district, Uttarakhand on Thursday

Sood reviews solar policy, power reforms in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Power Minister Ashish Sood on Thursday chaired a high-level review meeting with the Additional Chief Secretary and Special Secretary of the Power Department.

The meeting covered four key priorities: accelerating rooftop solar adoption across Government buildings and residential clusters, deploying large-scale battery energy storage systems to stabilise the grid, integrating Multi-Utility Ducts in Chandni Chowk to remove overhead wiring, and strengthening DISCOM accountability through improved performance metrics and audit mechanisms.

On DISCOM accountability, the meeting discussed stream-



lining performance metrics and audit mechanisms to ensure power distribution companies maintain transparent operations and strict consumer service standards.

The accountability framework for DISCOMs has been a recurring concern in Delhi's power sector, where the three distribution companies, BSES Rajdhani, BSES Yamuna, and TPDDL, operate under regulatory oversight but have faced periodic criticism over billing accuracy, outage response times, and consumer service quality.

Rahul, Kharge misleading on Amit Shah, says Prasad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

BJP MP Ravi Shankar Prasad on Thursday accused Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge of spreading a "false narrative" about Home Minister Amit Shah and disrupting Parliament to avoid a debate on issues raised by the Opposition.

The remarks came amid continued adjournments of both the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha due to relentless protests by the Opposition over student issues and the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya. Speaking to reporters in the Parliament House complex, Prasad said Home Minister Shah remains available in Parliament every day and is prepared to respond to the opposition's allegations if the House is allowed to function.

"Rahul Gandhi and Kharge ji come up with a new story and poster every day and keep demanding that Amit Shah be called to the House. The Union home minister sits in his chamber from 10 am to 7 pm every day.

"He is there even now. Let the House function first and let a debate take place. Once the debate begins, he will speak and give a strong reply," Prasad said.

The former Union minister alleged that the Opposition has been prevent-



ing Parliament from functioning while simultaneously accusing the Government of avoiding discussion.

"But you do not allow the House to function; you do not allow any debate. You keep creating a ruckus while Amit Shah is sitting there and then demand that he be called. We also come and sit in the House, but there is continuous disruption and then proceedings are adjourned," he said.

"Kharge ji, Rahul Gandhi ji, just look ahead. He (Shah) is sitting in his chamber, ready to hear your arguments and respond," he added.

Prasad alleged that Gandhi and Kharge, the Leaders of the Opposition

in the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha respectively, have sought to mislead the country through a false "narrative".

"Whether it is the prime minister, the home minister, the BJP or the NDA, everyone is ready to answer every single point. They are ready to listen and respond.

"Completely false and baseless allegations are being made. The country must know the truth," he said.

Prasad also targeted the Congress over alleged irregularities in examinations conducted in Jharkhand, claiming that the State Government had entrusted multiple examinations to a blacklisted company.

UP CM pushes youth policy with focus on education, jobs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Thursday directed officials to prepare an integrated youth policy aligned with the aspirations and expectations of the state's young population, with a focus on education, skill development, employment, health and leadership.

Chairing a review



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath during an event organised for the formation of Nomadic Development Board for the welfare of the freed and nomadic community at Kalidas Marg in Lucknow

meeting, Adityanath said the policy should be drafted after assessing the needs

and aspirations of people in the 16-35 age group, according to a press statement.

Delhi BJP pays tribute to Sushma Swaraj on death anniversary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP leaders, including Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and State president Harsh Malhotra, paid tributes to former external affairs minister Sushma Swaraj on her death anniversary on Thursday, recalling her contributions to the city and the country.

The party leaders also planted saplings at the Delhi BJP office and Vasant

Bhakra dam structure completely safe, says Punjab water minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Punjab Water Resources Minister Barinder Kumar Goyal on Thursday asserted that the structure of the Bhakra Dam is completely safe and there was no reason for panic.

Speaking during the Zero Hour in the Punjab Vidhan Sabha here, Goyal said some media reports claiming that the Bhakra Dam had tilted created unnecessary fear among people.

He explained that the dam's temporary movement is a normal part of its engineering design. The dam is built to experience slight movements due to increased water pressure and is designed to return to its original position once the pressure decreases, he said.

According to Goyal, the reported movement of just 1.03 inches is well within the dam's engineering design parameters. He noted that between 1995 and 2025, similar movements had been recorded 15 times, and in each instance, the structure returned to its normal position without any safety concerns.

He emphasised that the



Punjab Water Resources Minister Barinder Kumar Goyal

recent movement observed in 2025 was also part of the dam's normal structural behaviour and did not suggest any structural weakness or danger. Goyal urged people not to be misled by misinformation and reiterated that the dam is safe.

Addressing concerns regarding silt accumulation, the minister clarified that the deposited silt is located nearly 12 kilometres upstream of the dam wall and has no connection with the dam's structural stability.

While he acknowledged that approximately 26 per cent of silt accumulation has reduced the reservoir's storage capacity, he stressed that this does not impact the dam's safety.

FCRA Bill debate in LS on August 12

In a memorandum submitted to Shah, Lalduhma, along with Mizoram Kohhran Hruaitu Committee (MKHC) chairman John Raldosanga and Council of Churches in Mizoram (CCM) general secretary Lalmhangaia, said the Bill and its rules should operate prospectively as retrospective application of regulatory provisions may create uncertainty and expose bona fide organisations to penalties for past procedural variations. The MKHC and CCM represent major church denominations in Mizoram.

"Prospective application, accompanied by saving clauses and transitional safeguards, would ensure that national regulatory objectives are achieved without disrupting schools, healthcare units, and social safety nets that have been built over decades of dedicated service," the memorandum said.

Lalduhma and the church leaders said organisations which voluntarily choose to discontinue foreign funding or undergo restructuring should not be regarded as defaulting entities.

"Such decisions are, in fact, acts of compliance and transparency, reflecting a willingness to disengage from foreign contributions in good faith. Their assets, acquired legitimately and dedicated to public welfare, ought to remain protected so that they may continue serving their charitable purposes without interruption," they said.

The memorandum also said allowing continuity in the use of these assets would preserve vital community services such as schools, hospitals, orphanages, and rehabilitation centres, while also demonstrating the Government's commitment to fairness, proportionality, and the encouragement of voluntary compliance.

"This approach would reassure civil society that lawful welfare initiatives are valued, and that the regulatory framework seeks to strengthen cooperation rather than penalise genuine organisations," it said.

The Catholic Bishops' Conference of India (CBCI) had earlier urged Shah to withdraw the FCRA Bill and the notified rules, stressing that both be redrafted after wider consultation with stakeholders.

The CBCI had submitted a memorandum to Shah on July 10, raising concerns over the proposed Bill.

MeitY unveils tougher rules for AI content

Non-compliance with these regulations may result in the loss of safe-harbour protection under Section 79 of the IT Act.

Officials say the old 36-hour response time was not enough once content went viral. The new labelling rules are meant to help users tell real content from synthetic material. The rules also make it clear that SGI counts as 'information' under current laws, covering an area that was not regulated before.

A 24-hour deadline for all unlawful content, even beyond high-risk material, leaves little time for thorough human review. Because of this, platforms may rely more on automated systems, which could lead to the removal of lawful speech, parody, satire, or political commentary. It is hard to tell the difference between deepfakes

and protected expression in such a short time. Costs for following the rules are expected to go up, and keeping up with moderation, detection tools, and persistent identifiers will be tough, especially for smaller platforms.

Observers note that the final rules replaced the draft's 10 per cent visual-area labelling rule with a more flexible 'prominent' standard, allowing for technical and creative differences. Even with this change, the shorter takedown deadlines are still hard to meet. The rules now require reasoned notices instead of simple orders, but the faster timeline gives platforms or users little chance to challenge orders before content is removed. Free-speech advocates worry that platforms might remove content too quickly to keep safe-harbour protection. Consistent enforcement by officials and courts is needed to avoid unfair results. These changes are India's most detailed rules for generative AI and online platforms so far.

Bombay HC convicts Tarun Tejpal for rape...

"Both parties (the victim and Tejpal) may have moved on in life," the court said. The court asked Tejpal to surrender within two weeks but later extended the period to four weeks on a request from his lawyers.

In its 81-page judgment, the high court expressed strong disapproval about the way the defence put the victim in the dock and focused on her personal life, and said it found it surprising that the trial court "remained silent and allowed the defence to harass and humiliate her during the cross examination". The prosecution had established its case "beyond every reasonable doubt" and the victim too had stood firm in her testimony, and hence it had no hesitation in believing her statement which was reliable and consistent, the court said. The trial court at Mapusa proceeded with the notion that a sexual assault complainant must behave in a stereotypical manner, and the victim in the present case had to be a "perfect victim", the court said.

"The 'perfect victim' concept, more formally known as an 'ideal victim', described an unspoken cultural archetype where a person is fully believed, sympathised with and granted legitimacy only if they exhibit absolute vulnerability, complete innocence and total passivity," the court said.

When a victim does not fit into this mould, then their trauma is devalued, it added.

Tejpal was convicted under several sections of the Indian Penal Code (IPC), including Section 376(2)(f) (rape committed by a person in a position of trust or authority), Section 354(a) (sexual harassment), and Section 354(b) (assault or use of criminal force with intent to disrobe). Under Section 376(2)(f), the maximum punishment is life imprisonment. The court also imposed a fine of ₹10,21,000 on Tejpal, and said that the "victim having suffered sexual assault would be handed over the entire fine amount". While Tejpal pleaded for leniency, claiming he was a "political victim" and the father of two daughters, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Go Government, demanded the maximum punishment to send a strong message that "no means no".

During the hearing on sentencing, Tejpal addressed the court in person to request lenien-

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cy. "I am 62 years old today. I am a father of two daughters. I have a wife. I am a political victim. My lawyers have also asked me to urge the court to show leniency," he said.

The HC, in its judgment, noted that every person deals with trauma differently, and neither the court nor the accused could decide how the victim should have reacted or processed her trauma following the sexual assault.

Govt reaches out to Congress on delimitation

This was the second time in the last couple of days that the parliamentary affairs minister spoke with the LoP on the phone. The minister also met him twice in the last 10 days for smooth functioning of the House.

On the Opposition's demand for Union Home Minister Amit Shah's presence in the House, Rijiju said the home minister has introduced Bills and has been present in Parliament, working from morning till evening. "Naturally, the minister whose Bill is under consideration remains present in the House," he said.

Referring to his call to Rahul, Rijiju said they may be political opponents but are not enemies. "Therefore, we should work together in the national interest. However, the impression created outside is that they are determined not to let Parliament function at all; but who ultimately suffers from that?" he asked.

The Government is making a fresh attempt for the passage of a Constitution amendment Bill to implement 33 per cent reservation for women in legislatures in 2029 and redraw the Lok Sabha constituencies to increase its numbers to 816 in the ongoing Monsoon Session. Seats are also expected to be increased in State and Union Territory Assemblies to accommodate 33 per cent reservation for women. The outreach to the principal Opposition party Congress and NDA allies comes nearly four months after a similar effort failed due to lack of numbers.

The Government also plans to meet other Opposition leaders, including Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav and DMK leadership, to gauge their view on the possible reintroduction of the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill.

A Government functionary said if the Government wants to reintroduce the delimitation Bill, it will be done in the ongoing session and ruled out convening a brief special session soon after the Independence Day weekend. Rijiju also dismissed convening any special session.

Meta faces second day of grilling

The Government read out provisions of Section 79 of the Information Technology Act, making it clear that non-compliance in discharging intermediary obligations jeopardises the company's safe harbour protection (immunity as a platform).

Meta's global affairs head Joel Kaplan, who served in the administration of George W Bush, including as White House Deputy Chief of Staff for Policy, before joining Meta (then Facebook) in 2011, was summoned by the Government to explain why the restriction. On Wednesday, Kaplan and his team met IT Secretary S Krishnan, and then the IT

Minister. After the meeting, Government sources said Meta executives admitted to failures involving child sexual abuse content and deepfakes and admitted that "a lot of money was paid for boosting a certain type of content". Vaishnaw, it is learnt, also asked Meta if it is doing enough to prevent illegal content on their platform. "They admitted that their systems are not fully geared up for so much of the illegal content. They admitted that they are not able to control all of it," Government sources said.

On Wednesday, Government sources said Meta had apologised for the temporary removal of PM post as well as for failures ranging from child sexual abuse content to deepfakes. Kaplan said in a written statement that he apologised to the minister on behalf of Meta for the error. Government sources added that the apology originated from company chief executive Mark Zuckerberg.

A Parliamentary Standing Committee headed by BJP Lok Sabha MP Nishikant Dubey had earlier sought an apology from Zuckerberg over the removal of the post, warning that protection and immunity available could be withdrawn if no response was forthcoming within three days.

Neither Kaplan nor any other Meta official acknowledged the claims or offered any comments on Wednesday. The Government last month served a notice on Meta over alleged child sexual abuse material in paid advertisements on Instagram, and the meetings this week have seen the US giant being grilled on issues such as child sexual abuse material, deepfakes, safeguards for verified and prominent accounts, algorithmic bias, and compliance with Indian laws.

MDR on UPI gets LS nod

"All users of UPI will reap the benefits of this investment. More importantly, the UPI and Services Steering Committee headed by NPCI is yet to decide on the MDR. This will happen after the Parliament passes the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which proposes to amend Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007," she added.

The Bill does not impose any charges immediately. Instead, it empowers the Union Government to determine which payments may stay free and which ones will entail an MDR via further announcements. Real-time payments made through RTGS and NEFT are done by paying a service charge.

UPI transactions have been exempted from such charges so far. The proposed changes is a part of comprehensive legislation on taxation, which was introduced in the House on Tuesday.

Through the amendment, the Government has now been empowered to determine through notifications which payment methods would continue to have zero charges. Therefore, the Bill itself does not announce any fee or timeline for introducing charges.

Protest is part of democracy...

The BJP Government's handling of the protests, which turned violent during the July 20 march to Parliament in New Delhi called by the CJP, has invited criticism from different quarters.

"There should be dialogue. What should happen if dialogue does not work can be consid-

ered later," the RSS leader opined in response to a question posed to him during an interaction at the event.

He argued Gen Z seeks logical answers to their queries along with warmth and respect, unlike earlier generations that tended to accept what elders said without questioning.

Bhagwat maintained that during conflicts with countries such as Pakistan or China, citizens must stand with the Government and the armed forces, but stressed that such situations should not permanently disrupt dialogue or people-to-people ties.

Responding to a question on whether people-to-people dialogue should continue during conflicts with Pakistan or China, he said, "In times of conflict, we have to go with whatever the Government or military does. But that should not sever the ties which are already there."

He noted India's approach was not to "conquer or obliterate others" but to pursue a "harmonious assimilating process", which required dialogue.

"During conflicts, dialogue can be halted, but conflict should not sever dialogue. After a conflict is resolved, we have to take it forward from where we left it. Permanent animosity or hatred is not the solution," Bhagwat stated.

"When there is trouble, we have to deal with it in the proper way, and during conflict we are with our Government and military. But it is a temporary situation arising out of politics. It is not that Pakistanis are wholeheartedly enemies of Indians or vice versa. The state, politics and international borders are facts of life," Bhagwat said.

On the LGBTQIA+ community and legalisation for same-sex marriage, he noted people from the group were part of Indian society and there had been a tradition of accommodating them. "LGBTQIA+ people are part of our society. There were systems to accommodate them. Marriage is not merely a convenience for two people to live together. The family is a unit of society where the next generation is trained to become good citizens. If we disturb the existing system without creating a new one, it could lead to conflict," Bhagwat argued. "We have to prepare society first. Laws don't dictate society; society dictates the laws. At this stage, if we tamper with the marriage system, it may create side effects. We need to prepare a system that accommodates all such people. Our approach has to change and special measures have to be taken," he stated.

On same-sex couples, Bhagwat said a suitable social and legal framework would have to be devised.

Bhagwat said banning social media was not the solution to its harmful effects, asserting society must develop self-discipline and verify information from authentic sources before believing anything online.

He stressed rules and regulations alone would not work unless people's attitudes change. "Rules and discipline are necessary, but they succeed only when attitudes change. Many laws have been made. What matters is changing people's mindset," the RSS leader maintained.

Warning about the misuse of technology, the RSS chief said people should not trust content on social media without verification. "Today, technology can create fake videos using our faces and voices. Knowing this, people should never believe anything on social media without verifying it from authentic sources," he suggested.

No ethanol in ATF: Govt rejects Kejriwal’s allegations and calls them irresponsible

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The political war over India's ethanol blending programme escalated on Thursday after Union civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu Kinjarapu and BJP IT Cell chief Amit Malviya strongly dismissed Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convenor Arvind Kejriwal claim that the Centre plans to introduce ethanol blending in diesel and aviation turbine fuel (ATF).

Naidu in a post on X dismissed claims that it is planning to blend ethanol with aviation turbine fuel (ATF), calling the reports “completely false and irresponsible” and urging people not to spread misinformation on aviation safety. He said there is “no such proposal” under consideration by the Government.”

“The claim that the Government plans to blend ethanol with Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) is completely false and irresponsible. There is no such proposal,” Naidu said. He clarified that ethanol and sustainable aviation fuel (SAF) are “entirely different” fuels and should not be confused with one another.

The exchange comes after Kejriwal alleged that the Centre was planning to increase ethanol blending beyond current levels, claimed there were plans to mix ethanol into Aviation



Union civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu Kinjarapu

Turbine Fuel (ATF), and accused the Government of suppressing scientific concerns over E20 petrol. Kejriwal urged people to avoid purchasing new petrol and diesel vehicles for the time being. In a post on X in Hindi, Kejriwal alleged the Government planned to increase ethanol blending in petrol beyond 50 per cent after introducing E20 fuel.

Explaining the distinction, Naidu said SAF is an internationally certified aviation fuel recognised by the International Civil Aviation Organisation (ICAO) and has been adopted globally. He added that it undergoes rigorous testing and meets stringent international safety standards before being approved for use.

“Ethanol and Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF) are entirely different and should not be conflated. SAF is an internationally certified aviation

fuel recognised by International Civil Aviation Organisation (ICAO) and adopted globally. It undergoes rigorous testing and meets stringent global safety standards,” he said.

The minister also cautioned against circulating misleading claims related to aviation, saying such misinformation only creates unnecessary anxiety among air travellers. “Spreading misinformation on aviation safety only creates needless anxiety among air travellers. Passenger safety remains the Government’s highest priority,” he said. Slamming Kejriwal, Malviya said spreading “fake news” and creating undue “panic” is his “old habit”, and asserted that the Centre has clearly stated that there was no decision on ethanol mixing beyond E20.

Former Delhi chief minister, replying to Malviya, alleged that the Government

is waiting for the situation to calm down before implementing further ethanol blending in fuel. “Just like E20 was implemented without any scientific study, without listening to anyone, by silencing everyone through threats, you’ll implement E50 in the same way,” Kejriwal said, alleging this was the Government’s “style of functioning” without respecting science, engineering and technology. He challenged Malviya to publicly release any study conducted before implementing E20 petrol.

Malviya hit back in another post on X, saying Kejriwal’s entire argument was based not on facts but “fear”. “First, the Government has clearly stated that no decision has been taken to increase ethanol blending beyond E20. Raising a debate on some imaginary E50 is nothing but politics of spreading fear,” he replied to Kejriwal.

He refuted the AAP leader’s charge, stating it is completely wrong to say that E20 was implemented “without any scientific study”. In another post on X, Malviya claimed E20 is not a hasty decision and the country’s ethanol blending programme has been progressing in a phased manner for over two decades. He said before implementing E20, extensive testing and consultations with all relevant parties were conducted.

Cabinet clears 135.87 km Guwahati-Tezpur corridor of NH-15 in Assam for ₹8,970 cr



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Union Cabinet on Thursday approved the development of 135.871 km, 4-lane access-controlled Guwahati-Tezpur Corridor of NH-15 in Assam for ₹8,970.20 crore. According to an official statement, the project will be developed on a build-operate-transfer (BOT) toll mode.

The project envisages construction of an emergency landing facility (ELF) (4.9 Km) in Tezpur Bypass, which has been finalised in coordination with IAF and would decongest existing NH-27 (East West Corridor) on the south side of the Brahmaputra river.

The project includes construction of five major bypasses, thereby easing congestion on stretches passing through densely populated areas such as Baihata Chariali, Sipajhar, Kharupetia, Dekiajuli, Tezpur.

In addition, the project has provision for 15 major bridges, 30 minor bridges, 19

flyovers, 1 elephant under pass (in Tezpur bypass), 46 underpasses and 19 flyovers.

The project will increase average travel speed by 100 per cent, reduce travel time to half, improve overall road safety, enhance fuel efficiency, and lower vehicle operating costs, thereby enhancing regional mobility and socio-economic development, it added. The project will provide seamless connectivity to key economic, social, and logistics nodes across Assam and Arunachal Pradesh.

The upgraded corridor will enhance connectivity to eight PM Gati-Shakti Economic Nodes (8 Industrial Parks), two Social Nodes (2 Aspirational districts of Darrang and Udalguri), three Tourist Notes (Maa Kamakhya Temple, Kaziranga National Park, Orang National Park) and seven Logistic Nodes (3 Major Railway Stations, 2 Airports, 2 Waterway Terminals), facilitating faster movement of goods and passengers across the region.

States Focus



TN CM VIJAY TO HOLD MEET WITH MPs ON DELIMITATION

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay will chair a high-level consultation meeting with members of Parliament from the state on August 8 to discuss the Centre’s proposed constituency delimitation exercise and its potential impact on the State.

The meeting with Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha MPs will take place at the Kalaivanar Arangam here.

Invitations are currently being dispatched to all parliamentarians through the Tamil Nadu House in New Delhi, an official release here said on Thursday.

According to the reports, the Centre is likely to organise a special three-day parliamentary session from August 16 to 18 to revive the Delimitation Bill, 2026 along with the Women’s Reservation Amendment, though official confirmation has not been revealed.

(PTI)



TELANGANA TOPS IN COUNTRY IN CYBERCRIME INITIATIVES

Telangana was ranked first in the country in several cybercrime initiatives, in a nationwide review meeting held by the PMO on Thursday, a senior official said.

The “PRAGATI” review meeting was conducted to assess the implementation and performance of various states in cybercrime as well as performance and utilisation of the digital platforms developed by the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), Ministry of Home Affairs.

“During the review, Telangana was applauded for its efforts in the country for setting up the first S4C, implementation of e-Zero FIR and in the effective utilization of key I4C portals, including the Samanvaya portal, Sahyog portal, GRM portal, and MRM,” Telangana Cyber Security Bureau (TGCSB) Director Shikha Goel said in a release.

(PTI)

CRPF issues show-cause notices to eight officers for declining working lunch

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) has sent show-cause notices to eight Assistant Commandant-rank officers, including one woman, for reportedly refusing to attend an official working lunch hosted by a senior officer during a training program, according to official sources. The officers were part of a group taking a technical course at a CRPF camp in Madhya Pradesh about a month ago. Sources said the zonal head, an Indian Police Service (IPS) officer,

invited them to a working lunch. The officers did not attend, and the force has called this insubordination.

An internal communication shared with the media said the trainee officers were attending the Gazetted Officers’ technical course. Amit Kumar, IPS, Special Director General, Central Zone, hosted the lunch at the GO’s Mess. The first show-cause notice was sent on June 30, 2026, asking the officers to explain their actions within three days.

More than a month later, the units involved had not replied. Force headquarters



then sent a follow-up marked “Most Urgent,” telling the units to ensure the officers submit their explanations immediately. The message warned that if they did not

respond, it would be considered as having “nothing to state in their defence,” and action could be taken without their input.

Official sources said the

case is being treated as insubordination. A senior CRPF officer said more disciplinary action may follow after the officers submit their explanations and the force reviews them.

The reasons why the officers declined to attend the lunch have not been specified. CRPF headquarters has not made a public statement on the matter and has not responded to requests for comment.

Assistant Commandants are the entry-level gazetted officer rank in the CRPF. The force, which is the country’s largest central armed police organisation, regularly holds

technical and professional courses for its officers at different training centres.

Force headquarters have sent out the notices, and units have been told to collect the officers’ replies as soon as possible. What happens next will depend on the explanations provided and the review by the proper authority. Sources said the Special Director General was unhappy that the officers missed the lunch, which led to the show-cause process. No other details about earlier interactions between the officers and the senior officer have been shared.

Do anything to ensure return of Tatas to West Bengal: Industries minister Tapas Roy

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The Bengal Government would go any distance to bring the Tatas to the State, Industries Minister Tapas Roy has said. Roy, who had led a delegation of State Government officials to Mumbai on Thursday, said that he would have held the feet of Ratan Tata — “in any case he was much older than me in age” — had he been alive today. “Had Mr Ratan Tata been alive today, I would have even held his feet to

request him to return to Bengal,” reiterating that the then land movement led by former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee forcing the banishment of a fully developed Tata Nano (car) from Singur in 2008 was a colossal blunder.

Roy’s statement is in sync with a sustained effort by the Suvendu Adhikari Government to reach out to the investors, including Tatas, Birlas and others, to invest in Bengal “to restore it to its original position in the top where we belonged years ago.”

Bengal Government has to pay the Tata group a compensation of ₹765 crore in the wake of its forced abandonment of the Singur project. “The previous Governments have left a debt burden of ₹8 lakh crore... we will also have to repay the Tatas the compensation... still our Chief Minister is dreaming of bringing industry back to the State... we will make Bengal an industrialised State by 2031... a draft industrial policy is already there and will be unveiled by the middle of



West Bengal Industries Minister Tapas Roy

Haryana Minister Rajesh Nagar meets Amit Shah, discusses development and public welfare

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Haryana’s Minister for Food, Civil Supplies and Consumer Affairs, Rajesh Nagar, paid a courtesy call on Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah in New Delhi on Thursday. During the meeting, the two leaders held detailed discussions on Haryana’s development, public welfare initiatives, and various contemporary issues.

During the interaction, Minister Rajesh Nagar briefed the Union Home Minister on the progress of key schemes being implemented by the Food and Civil Supplies Department.

He also discussed measures to further strengthen the Public Distribution System (PDS), improve service delivery for citizens, and accelerate development through enhanced coordination between the Central and State Governments.

Rajesh Nagar expressed his gratitude to the Union Government for its continued support towards Haryana’s development and



sought the guidance of Amit Shah on further strengthening the state’s growth trajectory. He said that under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the guidance of Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Haryana is achieving new milestones in development. He reiterated the State Government’s commitment to ensuring the effective implementation of public welfare schemes for the benefit of every citizen.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah also reviewed the progress of various

ly strong state within 2-3 years... we will hand over land to at least 25 industries within a month,” he said.

Announcing that he would lay the foundation stone of a ₹4,000 crore steel plant in Purulia district, Adhikari said that the administration would not allow any extortion racket to thrive in the State.

“Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman has expressed keen interest in textile and industries ... she has seen the high-quality of products woven by our weavers ... she

is coming here” in the last week of August but “for that we need a business-friendly atmosphere.”

“For the past 50 years or so Bengal has fallen behind because of hooliganism and extortion raj that will not be tolerated any more... you may have seen the Government’s attitude... There will be no extortion or hooliganism, syndicates, cut-money; now we are determined to ensure a business-friendly environment,” Adhikari said.

India demonstrates strategic might with successful Agni-4 missile test



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India on Thursday successfully test-fired nuclear-capable ballistic missile Agni-4 from the integrated test range in Odisha’s Chandipur, demonstrating its strategic strike capabilities.

The testing of the missile was carried out by the Strategic Forces Command (SFC) and the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO). “Medium Range Ballistic Missile ‘Agni-4’ was successfully test-fired from the Integrated Test Range, Chandipur in Odisha on August 6,” the defence ministry said.

“The launch validated all operational and technical parameters. The test was carried out under the aegis of the Strategic Forces Command,” it said.

■ States Focus ■



SONIA GANDHI APPOINTS NEERAJ DANGI AS CONGRESS WHIP IN RS

Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi has appointed party MP Neeraj Dangi as party's whip in the Rajya Sabha. Jairam Ramesh said Dangi's appointment comes in the wake of the vacancy created after the retirement of Rajani Patil.

"Chairperson, Congress Party in Parliament, Sonia Gandhi has appointed Neeraj Dangi as whip of the Congress party in Parliament, Rajya Sabha, vice vacancy arising owing to the retirement of Rajani Ashokrao Patil," Ramesh, the party's chief whip, said in a statement. Dangi represents the state of Rajasthan in the Council of States. He is a two-term MP and was re-elected recently to the Rajya Sabha. (PNS)



GUJARAT GEARS UP FOR CHEETAH REINTRODUCTION IN KUTCH

Gujarat has moved a step closer to introducing cheetahs in the Banni grasslands of Kutch, with preparations gathering pace for the ambitious conservation initiative. According to forest officials, four to six cheetahs are likely to be brought from Madhya Pradesh's Kuno National Park after the monsoon season, while the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) has indicated that an initial batch of four cheetahs could be sent to the Banni Cheetah Breeding Centre.

To ensure a sustainable habitat, authorities have begun strengthening the prey base in line with NTCA guidelines. As part of the exercise, blackbucks from Velavadar National Park are being relocated to Banni. (PNS)

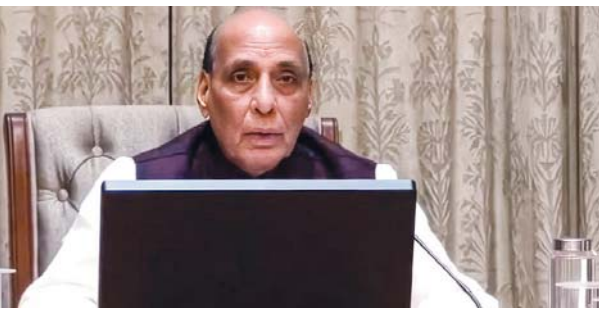
Rajnath reviews ways to enhance effectiveness of territorial army

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday chaired a meeting of a parliamentary committee, with discussions focusing on the Territorial Army and its members offering suggestions to further enhance its overall effectiveness. He said the Territorial Army creates surge capacity for the defence forces by building a reserve of trained soldiers who can be deployed immediately whenever the need arises. Rajnath made this assertion while chairing the meeting.

Minister of State for Defence Sanjay Seth, Chief of Defence Staff General NS Raja Subramani, Army Chief General Dhiraj Seth, Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh, Secretary (Defence Production) Sanjeev Kumar, Secretary (Defence Finance) Vishvajit Sahay and other senior officers attended the meeting, the ministry said in a statement.

During the meet, senior officials presented a detailed briefing on the Territorial Army's mandate, role and key achieve-



Union Defence Minister Rajnath Singh chairs a Parliamentary Consultative Committee meeting regarding Territorial Army for the Ministry of Defence in New Delhi

ments to the committee members, who offered suggestions to further strengthen the force and enhance its overall effectiveness, it said.

In his address, Rajnath described the Territorial Army's contribution as "significant" in advancing Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led Government's vision of Viksit Bharat. He emphasised that while the role of the defence forces revolves primarily around security-related aspects, the Territorial Army contributes in other areas such as environmental conservation and social work as well.

"The Territorial Army is a living embodiment of the 'citizen-soldier' concept. While its members engage in civilian pursuits, they simultaneously don the uniform to safeguard the borders and maintain internal security," Singh said. He added that when the personnel complete their tenure and return to civilian life, they act as a "vibrant bridge" between society and the military, inspiring people, especially the youth, to join the defence forces.

The Territorial Army stands as a trained, motivated, and potent force, comprising

nearly 44,400 personnel and 59 diverse units, the ministry said. The defence minister termed the force as "first responders", who provide immediate relief and support during natural calamities.

He acknowledged their role in carrying out relief and rescue work, and providing medical aid to those in need during Kerala floods, Odisha cyclone and the recent floods in Assam.

Commending their contribution in environmental management and climate change mitigation, he said the ecological task forces of the Territorial Army have planted approximately 10 crore saplings till date, with the survival rate ranging between 80-85 per cent.

This green initiative is translating the prime minister's 'Mission LiFE' and 'Panchamrit' goals into reality on the ground, he said.

Rajnath also appreciated the efforts of the Territorial Army deployed in Jammu and Kashmir for taking the 'Har Ghar Tiranga' campaign to greater heights.

PM Modi's foreign visits cost ₹74.5 crore this year, Govt tells Parliament

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The Centre on Thursday informed the Rajya Sabha that Prime Minister Narendra Modi's overseas visits this year have cost the exchequer nearly ₹74.5 crore, while also stating that India attracted USD 381.8 billion in Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) between April 2021 and December 2025. However, the Government did not attribute any portion of the investment inflows to specific foreign visits or agreements.

The information was shared by the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) in a written reply

to questions raised by Rajya Sabha MPs Sanjay Singh and Dr V. Sivadasan.

The lawmakers had sought details of the Prime Minister's country-wise foreign visits since 2021, the expenditure incurred on each trip, bilateral agreements signed, investment commitments made, and the FDI received as a result of those visits.

Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita said the Government has provided year-wise and visit-wise expenditure details along with a country-wise list of Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) signed



during the Prime Minister's visits in annexures attached to the reply.

The MEA also referred to expenditure incurred during

the previous Congress-led UPA Government to provide historical context. According to the ministry, a single visit by former Prime Minister

Dr Manmohan Singh to the United States in 2011 cost ₹10.74 crore, while visits to Russia in 2013, France in 2011, and Germany in 2013 cost ₹9.96 crore, ₹8.33 crore, and ₹6.02 crore, respectively.

The ministry clarified that these are actual historical figures and have not been adjusted for inflation or currency fluctuations.

On the investment front, the Government said India received a cumulative USD 381.8 billion in FDI between April 2021 and December 2025. It maintained that the Prime Minister's high-level foreign engagements have played an

important role in strengthening India's bilateral, regional, and global partnerships.

According to the MEA, agreements signed during these visits have expanded cooperation across key sectors, including technology, innovation, trade and investment, defence, energy, and resilient supply chains.

The Government, however, did not provide any visit-specific assessment of investment outcomes, nor did it quantify how much of the reported FDI could be directly linked to individual overseas trips, MoUs, or investment commitments.

PM Modi and Netanyahu review strategic partnership, discuss West Asia developments

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday held a telephone conversation with his Israeli counterpart, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, during which the two leaders reviewed the progress of the India-Israel Special Strategic Partnership and exchanged views on the evolving security and geopolitical situation in West Asia.

According to an official statement issued by the Prime Minister's Office, the conversation reflected the continued high-level engagement between New Delhi and Tel Aviv, with both leaders reaffirming their shared commitment to further deepening bilateral cooperation across a broad spectrum of sectors for the mutual benefit of the two nations.

The discussion underscored the growing maturity of India-Israel ties, which have expanded significantly over the past decade to encompass defence and security, agriculture, water management, innovation, cyber security, artificial intelligence, space technology, renewable energy, healthcare, and trade. Both sides acknowledged the sustained momentum in the Special Strategic Partnership and reiterated their resolve to strengthen collaboration in emerging technologies and critical infrastructure.

The two Prime Ministers also exchanged perspectives on recent developments in West Asia, a region that continues to witness significant political and security challenges with implications for regional stability and the global economy. While the official statement did not disclose specific details of the discussion, the exchange reflects India's



continued diplomatic engagement with key regional stakeholders amid evolving geopolitical dynamics.

India has consistently advocated dialogue, restraint, respect for international law, and peaceful resolution of conflicts, while maintaining close relations with countries across West Asia. New Delhi's balanced diplomatic approach has enabled it to engage constructively with multiple partners in the region while safeguarding its strategic, economic, and energy interests.

The conversation between Prime Minister Modi and Prime Minister Netanyahu comes at a time when India and Israel continue to enhance cooperation in areas of mutual strategic importance.

Defence collaboration remains a cornerstone of the bilateral relationship, complemented by growing partnerships in technology, innovation, start-

up ecosystems, agriculture, and water conservation. Increasing business-to-business engagement and people-to-people exchanges have further reinforced the relationship.

The leaders agreed to remain in close contact and continue consultations on issues of bilateral and regional significance.

Their decision to maintain regular dialogue underscores the importance both countries attach to sustained political engagement in addressing common challenges and advancing shared strategic objectives.

The telephone conversation reflects the enduring strength of the India-Israel partnership and the commitment of both Governments to further expanding cooperation while remaining engaged on regional developments that have far-reaching international implications.

Government amends drug rules to debar firms submitting fake data for approvals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre has amended the Drugs Rules, 1945, to empower licensing authorities to debar applicants who submit fake or fabricated data in support of applications for regulatory approvals, a move aimed at strengthening the integrity and transparency of India's drug regulatory system.

The Union Health Ministry said the amendments, notified through GS R 756(E), introduce a new enforcement mechanism in addi-



tion to the existing provisions under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940. Under the amended rules, applicants found to have submitted fabricated data may be barred from filing fresh appli-

cations with the concerned licensing authority, either the Centre or the state regulator, as applicable, for a specified period.

"In addition to existing enforcement provisions

under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940, these newly notified provisions empower the Licensing Authority to debar further applications by entities who submit fake or fabricated data in support of their applications.

"This will apply to all applications filed under various provisions of the Drugs Rules 1945," the ministry said in a statement. Currently, applicants who submit fabricated data face enforcement actions such as rejection of their applications or cancellation of existing licenses.

AIKS alleges 2026 Forest Rights Guidelines undermine tribal rights and dilute FRA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The All India Kisan Sabha (AIKS) has strongly criticised the Forest Rights Guidelines issued through a joint communication dated July 27, 2026, by the Ministry of Tribal Affairs and the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, alleging that they undermine both the letter and spirit of the Forest Rights Act (FRA).

According to AIKS, the communication sent to state chief secretaries directs

states to ensure that Community Forest Resource (CFR) plans are harmonised with forest department-approved working plans.

The organisation said the new guidelines supersede the 2015 guidelines issued under Section 12 of the FRA and build upon what it described as anti-democratic and anti-tribal guidance circulated in June 2021 and September 2023.

AIKS stated that the 2026 joint circular, like the previous communications issued in 2021 and 2023, contradicts the



fundamental intent and ethos of the FRA, particularly its commitment to community-centric forest governance.

The organisation noted that the FRA was enacted

following decades of struggles by Adivasis and other traditional forest dwellers, along with parliamentary interventions by the organised Left.

Regional party donations triple in 2 years, DMK tops list with ₹365 cr: ADR report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Regional parties in India have strongly influenced and reshaped the contours of the polity. This acceptance by the electorate is now reflected in their funding, which has seen a stupendous three-fold increase through donations between 2023 and 2025.

The amount received in donations by the regional parties was ₹1,051.56 crore in 2024-25, an increase of ₹688.769 cr (198.18 per cent), up from ₹347.69 crore in 2023-24, while the total number of donations received for the

two years were 5,297 and 2,861, respectively — denoting an 85 per cent increase.

Notably, Corporate and business houses continued to dominate political funding, contributing ₹644.93 crore in 2024-25, nearly three times the ₹227.61 crore amount donated in the previous year, though their share in the total value of donations declined marginally.

According to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms released on Thursday, donations from donors with undeclared addresses increased sharply in 2024-25, both in terms of

number (613 to 2,025 donations) and value (₹8.482 cr to ₹337.11 crore) while donations from donors with undeclared addresses totalled ₹345.594 cr through 2,638 donations across the two financial years, accounting for 24.7 per cent of the total value of donations received.

The ADR report said across the two financial years, corporate and business houses contributed ₹872.54 crore through 650 donations, adding up to over 62 per cent of the total value of contributions. Individual donors accounted for the largest number of donations,



making 5,647 contributions across two years. However, they contributed only ₹193.95 crore, or about 14 per cent of the total value of

donations. While the number of individual donations increased in 2024-25, their overall value declined, resulting in a sharp fall in their

share of total donations.

The report also flagged a sharp increase in donations from undeclared donors, which rose from ₹6.62 crore in 2023-24 to ₹302.67 crore in 2024-25, taking their share in the total value of donations to nearly 29 per cent.

The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) received the highest amount from undeclared donors at ₹300.64 crore, accounting for over 82 per cent of its total declared donations during the year. The Tamil Nadu-based party also topped the list of recipients in 2024-25 with declared donations of

₹365.78 crore, followed by the All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) at ₹184.96 crore and the YSR Congress at ₹140.04 crore. Notably, the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) had been the highest recipient in 2023-24 with ₹100.19 crore.

The report pointed out that AITC, YSR Congress, TDP, All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and Biju Janata Dal (BJD) relied almost entirely on corporate and business house donations, with negligible or no contributions from other donor categories. Prudent Electoral Trust emerged as the largest

donor across the two financial years, contributing ₹434 crore through 38 donations, followed by Tiger Associates with ₹160 crore.

Progressive Electoral Trust, Vedanta Limited and AB General Electoral Trust also featured among the top five donors.

Electoral trusts continued to dominate political funding, with Prudent Electoral Trust, Progressive Electoral Trust and AB General Electoral Trust together contributing ₹536 crore, or about 64 per cent of the total donations made by the top 10 donors during the two-year period.

J&K CM to meet PM Modi with special package proposal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Thursday said he will personally approach Prime Minister Narendra Modi with a proposal seeking a special central package for the flood-affected districts of Rajouri and Poonch.

He also noted that the union territory does not have the financial capacity to meet the entire cost of restoration on its own. "While there are some things we can manage on our own, the reality is that Jammu and Kashmir does not have the financial capacity to bear the entire cost of restoration.

"After last year's floods, the Central Government approved a package of nearly ₹1,400 crore for Jammu and Kashmir. This time too, we will prepare a detailed package and seek



Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah inspects the flood affected areas to assess the damage caused in Rajouri on Thursday

Central assistance," the chief minister told reporters after chairing a review meeting on flood relief and rehabilitation in Rajouri. He said floods, flash floods and cloudbursts are automatically treated as natural disasters and do not require any separate declaration before seeking Central assistance. "As soon as the proposal is ready, I will personally submit it to the prime

minister," Abdullah said. Reviewing the aftermath of the July 19 flash floods that claimed four lives in Rajouri district, the chief minister said the Government's response had been carried out in three phases — rescue, recovery and rehabilitation. "Our priority was to minimise the loss of human lives. We regret the loss of four precious lives in this district. Had the dis-

trict administration and police not acted promptly overnight, the death toll could have been much higher," he said.

Reaffirming his Government's commitment to the affected people, he assured them that every possible assistance would be extended to ensure timely relief, the rehabilitation of families, and the restoration of infrastructure. During the visit, the Chief Minister met the families of flood victims, conveyed his sympathies to the bereaved, and assured them of the Government's full support.

The Chief Minister later inspected the damaged Circular Road in Rajouri, where nearly 200 metres of the road was washed away in the July 19 flash floods. He also visited the flood-hit Aitey area to assess the extensive damage to residential areas, public infrastructure and local connectivity.

NIA nabs another absconding suspect in Praveen Nettaru PFI-linked murder case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) arrested Ummar Farook MR in Kochi, Kerala, on Wednesday. Farook had been on the run and is a main suspect in the July 2022 murder of Karnataka BJP Yuva Morcha leader Praveen Nettaru. This arrest brings the total number of people taken into custody in the case to 25.

According to the NIA, Farook was a key suspect. Authorities issued a Red Corner Notice, a non-bailable warrant, and offered a ₹4 lakh reward for his capture. He was charged under several sections of the Indian Penal Code and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act for his alleged role in the conspiracy.

Investigators found that he attended a planning meeting at the banned Popular Front of India (PFI) office in Sullia town. He is

accused of giving his motorcycle to a co-accused for identifying and watching the target in Bellare village before the attack. He is also accused of trying to eliminate a protected witness.

Praveen Nettaru, a district-level BJP leader, was killed on July 26, 2022, outside his poultry shop in Bellare, Dakshina Kannada district. According to the NIA, the murder was planned by PFI's 'Service Teams,' which are secret groups trained in weapons and surveillance. They aimed to spread fear, create communal tension, and support the group's goal of establishing Islamic rule by 2047.

Meetings in Bengaluru, Sullia, and Bellare discussed possible targets, and four Hindu leaders were considered before Nettaru was chosen. The attack was made to look like a response to other local killings, but investigators believe PFI members planned it carefully.



The agency took over the case in August 2022. Its first chargesheet named 20 people, many with direct links to the PFI, and listed several as fugitives with cash rewards for their capture. Since then, the investigation has made steady progress.

Chief conspirator Mustafa Paichar was arrested in 2024 after hiding in several states. Other suspects were caught at airports, in nearby states, or while using false identities.

In July 2026, the NIA arrested two more fugitives, Abdul Nasir P (also known as Nasir) from Kochi and Naushad from Hosur, after receiving information from Andhra Pradesh Police.

Farook was reportedly arrested after questioning these two men. Two suspects are still on the run, which shows that authorities can continue multi-state operations against the remaining networks of the

CPI(M) opposes MDR on UPI transactions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Polit Bureau of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) (CPI(M)) has expressed strong opposition to the Union Government's proposal to levy charges on Unified Payments Interface (UPI) transactions, alleging that the move breaches the Government's earlier commitment to keep the digital payment platform free.

In a statement, the CPI(M) said that under the Digital India initiative, the Narendra Modi-led Government had aggressively promoted digital payments and UPI as a free public utility.

The party noted that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had repeatedly urged citizens, small traders and businesses to shift from cash to digital transactions and had even appeared in advertisements, including those of a private payments company, promoting UPI. It also said that the promotion of digital payments was pre-



sented as one of the justifications for the 2016 demonetisation exercise.

The party alleged that after encouraging widespread adoption of UPI, the Government is now attempting to convert the public digital payments infrastructure into a source of revenue by proposing transaction charges.

According to the CPI(M), the move amounts to a breach of public trust, as

the Government had consistently maintained that UPI services would remain free for users.

The party further argued that the proposal should be viewed alongside what it described as a steady rise in banking-related charges over the past decade.

It cited penalties for non-maintenance of minimum account balances, higher charges for ATM transactions beyond prescribed limits,

debit card maintenance fees and SMS alert charges as examples that have made access to essential banking services more expensive.

The CPI(M) demanded the immediate withdrawal of the proposed legislation to impose charges on UPI transactions.

It also asserted that UPI should remain a free, universal and publicly accountable digital payment system accessible to all citizens.

Ladakh administration flags IAS officer over Pashmina co-op, seeks MHA action

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Leh

The Ladakh Administration has officially reported a major conflict of interest involving 2010-batch IAS officer G Prasanna Ramaswamy to the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA).

They have asked for action because he founded and led a cooperative society that later received significant Government and private funding while promoting Ladakh's Pashmina fibre.

In a letter dated July 30, 2026, the General Administration Department informed the Additional Secretary (JKL), Ministry of Home Affairs, that records for the "Looms of Ladakh Women Cooperative Society Ltd" show several irregularities.

The society was registered while Ramaswamy was Registrar of Cooperative Societies, and documents list both him and his wife, Abhilasha Bahuguna, as co-founders.

The Articles of Association made the District Collector of Leh the default Chairman. Since Ramaswamy held this post from 2015 to 2017, he became Chairman of the society. Department records do not show that he got approval from the right authority for this role.

This missing approval is at the heart of the conflict-of-interest claim, since he was both regulating and leading a cooperative he and his wife started.

The society later received grants and support from both Government and private sources, including financial help from the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development



(NABARD) and funding from various Corporate Social Responsibility initiatives. Official letters say the amount was "lakhs of rupees," but exact figures have not been shared.

More concerns came up when the society applied to register "Ladakh Pashmina Textiles" for Geographical Indication status. The application said it had approval from the Director of Industries, but records show this approval was never given.

An Examination Report from the Geographical Indications Registry on September 11, 2025, suggested creating a broader institutional framework and pointed out issues that needed to be fixed before the application could move forward.

PT Rudra Goud, IAS, Administrative Secretary of the General Administration Department, signed the letter and sent these details to the Ministry "for its kind consideration and for such action as may be deemed appropriate." Copies were also sent to the Administrative Secretaries of the Industries & Commerce and Cooperative Departments of the UT.

This case raises important questions about how institutions work in a sensitive border area, where Government support for local jobs, especially women's cooperatives linked to Pashmina, matters for both the economy and local pride.

When an officer is regulator, founder, and beneficiary, there is a real risk of favouritism, weak oversight, and loss of public trust. The ongoing funding of the society after registration shows why a full investigation is needed to check if civil servant rules about cooperatives were followed.

Ramaswamy is now posted in Jammu and Kashmir. The Ministry of Home Affairs has not yet said what action it will take or when. By sending all the documents to the central ministry, the UT Administration shows it is taking the issue seriously.

This situation highlights problems in the process when one person holds several roles connected to the same cooperative. The steps from registration to chairmanship to GI application suggest a pattern that needs outside review, not just an internal fix.

Creamy layer principle not applicable to quotas for SCs, STs: Govt's affidavit to SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre has told the Supreme Court that the principle of creamy layer was not applicable to reservation for Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs).

The Government has opposed PILs seeking implementation of the "creamy layer" principle in reservation for SCs and STs, and also the direction to the Centre to frame policies for a more equitable system of reservation in Government employment.

The Government said the PILs do not disclose any infringement of the fundamental rights under the Constitution.

"It has nowhere specifically been held that the principle of creamy layer is applicable to SCs and STs. The reference made to the concept of creamy layer... appears to be the general observation with regard to reservation in respect of OBCs (Other Backward Classes)/ SEBCs (Socially and Educationally



Backward Classes). "This has been clarified by a Constitution bench of this court in the case of Ashoka Kumar Thakur versus Union of India... that for the purpose of reservation, the principles of creamy layer are not applicable to SCs and STs," the Government said in its affidavit to the Supreme Court.

The creamy layer principle was first devised by the Supreme Court in its famous Mandal case verdict of 1992 by which certain affluent people belonging to the Backward Classes were

excluded from reservation in Government jobs and admissions in educational institutions.

The Government in its affidavit said, "That modification of reservation policy, particularly to introduce income-based preferences within reserved categories, should be preceded by a holistic review and thorough empirical study, including socio-economic data of reserved category beneficiaries."

It added that no direction can be issued to the executive to frame policy in a particular manner, which is

beyond the judicial domain. The Centre's affidavit sought dismissal of PILs filed by petitioners Ramashankar Prajapati and others, and advocate Ashwini Upadhyay, saying they were not maintainable under the law.

It said these petitions neither raise any question of law pertaining to the Constitution and which need interpretation of this court nor disclose the infringement of the fundamental rights under the Constitution and, therefore, were not maintainable under Article 32 and hence, deserve to be dismissed with exemplary cost.

The affidavit emphasised that fundamental rights guaranteed to the subject or subjects under Part III of the Constitution were negative in character and positive in sanction.

"In other words, the subject/s cannot enforce his fundamental right by way of filing a writ petition under Article 32 of the Constitution, unless and until it is infringed by the state," it said.

Kartavya Bhavan sets green benchmark, cuts electricity use by 76 per cent

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

'Sarkari daftar' often conjures a drab and unimaginative image. Defying this stereotype, the Kartavya Bhawan has become a trendsetter with world-class green building features, consuming 76 per cent less electricity and reducing fresh water consumption by 49 per cent compared to equivalent old buildings.

Kartavya Bhavan-3, one of the new Government office buildings under the Centre's ambitious Central Vista redevelopment plan, was inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on August 6 last year. The office of Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal said that Kartavya Bhavan stands as a shining example of New India's future-ready Government infrastructure.

"Designed with world-class green building features, the campus consumes 76 per cent less electricity, saving nearly 4.45 lakh units every month in a single block, and reduces fresh water consumption by 49 per cent by recycling and reusing around 3 lakh litres of water every day," it said in a post on X.

The minister's office said that with energy-efficient systems, a zero-discharge campus and smart resource management, Kartavya Bhawan is more than an administrative office — it is a symbol of modern, sustainable and citizen-centric governance, advancing the vision



of Viksit Bharat. The building is designed to use 30 per cent less energy.

It has special glass windows to keep the building cool and reduce outside noise. Solar panels on the roof of Kartavya Bhavan — 03 will generate over 5.34 lakh units of electricity every year. Solar water heaters meet more than a quarter of the daily hot water need. Charging stations for electric vehicles are also provided.

Kartavya Bhawan was the first of the 10 Common Central Secretariat (CCS) buildings being built under the Government's Central Vista Redevelopment Plan. So far, three new CCS buildings have been operationalised

while seven buildings are under construction. Under the Central Vista Redevelopment Plan, the Government has already constructed a new Parliament building and the Vice President Enclave, and redeveloped the Kartavya Path that spans from Vijay Chowk to India Gate.

Besides the Common Central Secretariat, the Government will also construct an Executive Enclave that will house a new Prime Minister's Office (PMO), Cabinet Secretariat, India House and National Security Council Secretariat. Under the second phase of the Executive Enclave, a new prime minister's residence will be constructed.

Editor's
TAKE

Assam floods: A national calamity

Floods play havoc in Assam every year, but the scale of this year's devastation calls for a robust and effective flood management strategy

Six more deaths on Wednesday pushed this monsoon's toll in Assam to 95, with over 1.6 lakh people affected across 563 villages in fourteen districts now on high alert. Embankments have breached in seven places. Nearly 17,000 hectares of cropland lie submerged. Relief camps have opened and the Centre has released emergency funds. All of it is necessary. None of it is new. That is the real story of Assam's floods: not that they happen, but that they happen on schedule. Last year the toll stood at 26 dead and 6.3 lakh affected. In 2022, the Brahmaputra submerged 32 of the state's 35 districts and displaced three million people. Each time, the same script plays out – rescue, relief, condolence, forgetting – until the next monsoon revives it. Some of this is geography. The Brahmaputra carries one of the heaviest silt loads of any river on Earth, steadily raising its own bed and narrowing its capacity to hold water. Assam's fifty-odd tributaries, fed by intense upstream rain in Arunachal Pradesh and Nagaland, can turn flash floods into disasters within hours, as Upper Assam districts unused to flooding at this scale discovered this year. But much of it is policy. Assam's chief flood defence remains nearly 4,800 km of embankments, of which the state's own water resources minister admits over 60 percent need repair. Roughly ₹30,000 crore has been spent on this approach over six decades, and by the water resources department's own admission, no long-term flood or erosion mitigation measures have ever been implemented – only short-term patchwork, rebuilt and re-breached every year. Wetlands that once absorbed excess water have been encroached upon for construction, including in Guwahati, where poor drainage now produces urban flooding on top of riverine flooding. And India still manages its most consequential upstream relationship, with China, through ad hoc hydrological data-sharing arrangements rather than a binding treaty, leaving early-warning systems partly blind upstream. There are signs of a better direction. Delhi approved ₹692 crore last October to restore two dozen wetlands across nine districts, explicitly framed as a shift from embankments toward natural flood buffers. Multilateral lenders have committed several hundred million dollars more toward a genuinely integrated, basin-wide approach. These are the right instincts. But they remain add-ons to a system still built around embankment contracts and annual relief cycles, not replacements for it. A real water policy for Assam would make basin-wide planning – flood control, irrigation, wetland restoration, urban drainage – the responsibility of one empowered authority, not scattered departments. It would zone floodplains against construction, fund flood mitigation as permanent infrastructure rather than emergency spending, and give riverine and char-dwelling communities, who have read these rivers for generations, a real seat in planning them. Assam does not lack rainfall warnings or relief funds. It lacks the political will to treat flooding as a governance failure as much as a natural one. Ninety-five deaths later, that is the reform actually due.

Handloom weaving the future of Viksit Bharat

As India marks the 12th National Handloom Day, it is time to view handloom as a strategic sector that values sustainability, authenticity and resilient supply chains



GIRIRAJ SINGH

The making of a developed nation is not defined by technology alone. It is shaped by the ability to transform enduring strengths into engines of future growth. As India advances towards Viksit Bharat 2047, we are investing in frontier technologies, strengthening manufacturing and building globally competitive industries. Yet one of our greatest strengths has been with us all along – our handloom tradition. On August 7, as India marks the 12th National Handloom Day, it is time to view handloom as a strategic sector for a world that values sustainability, authenticity and resilient supply chains.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of Viksit Bharat 2047 is built on prosperity, self-reliance, inclusivity and cultural confidence. Handloom embodies this vision by bringing together heritage and innovation, while driving women-led development, rural entrepreneurship, livelihoods and global competitiveness.

In the Vijay Rath discourse, Lord Rama teaches that lasting victory is built not on power, but on values. Those very values have sustained India's handloom tradition for centuries. Every handwoven fabric reflects the courage to preserve tradition, the patience to perfect every thread, the integrity of honest craftsmanship and the wisdom passed down through generations. That is why handloom is not merely a craft, but one of India's greatest civilisational strengths. From the Indus Valley Civilisation, where cotton was first cultivated and woven, to the eighteenth century when Indian textiles dominated global trade, India set global benchmarks in textile excellence. Bengal's legendary muslin, so fine that a 25 metre length could pass through a ring, along with Banarasi silk, Kanchipuram weaves, Pochampally Ikat and countless regional traditions, earned India worldwide admiration. Today, as the world turns towards authentic, sustainable and handcrafted products, we have a historic opportunity to reclaim that leadership. Our next handloom revolution must export not just textiles, but craftsmanship, heritage, innovation and trust, making every handwoven product an ambassador of Brand India.

Handloom is India's largest cottage industry, supporting the livelihoods of more than 35 lakh weavers and allied workers, nearly 72 per cent of whom are women. Over the past decade, the Government has strengthened the sector through the Raw Material Supply Scheme, 797 handloom

clusters, over 1.24 lakh improved looms, skill upgradation for nearly 97,000 artisans, and initiatives such as Producer Companies, GI tagged products, the Handloom Mark, India Handmade certification, Urban Haats and Design Resource Centres. Today, 29 Weavers' Service Centres provide end to end support through training, upskilling, design development, raw material assistance and market linkages, while the 11 Indian Institutes of Handloom Technology are being strengthened to expand advanced training and develop niche, high value handloom products. These initiatives mark a shift from supporting handloom as a welfare activity to building it as a globally competitive creative industry. The forthcoming National Handloom and Handicraft Programme will strengthen 1,800 clusters across 500 districts, benefit 65 lakh weavers and artisans, and establish Handmade in India as a globally recognised brand. The forthcoming National Handloom and Handicraft Programme will accelerate this transformation by strengthening 1,800 clusters across more than 500 districts, benefiting 65 lakh weavers and artisans and establishing Handmade in India as a globally recognised brand.

Innovation has always been part of India's handloom journey. Mahatma Gandhi's Ambar Charkha made spinning easier, faster and more efficient, advancing the vision of self-reliance. More recently, Assam's Maina Loom and the Chitrnanjan Handloom developed in Sivasagar have shown how better loom design can make weaving easier and more productive. Building on this legacy, the Centre of Excellence for Handloom Technology, established with the Indian Institutes of Technology, is developing lighter, stronger and easier to use looms that reduce physical effort and improve productivity, including for persons with disabilities. Under

EVERY HANDLOOM PRODUCT WE BUY AND WEAR STRENGTHENS A WEAVER'S LIVELIHOOD, PRESERVES A TIMELESS TRADITION AND CARRIES INDIA'S STORY TO THE WORLD. BY CHOOSING HANDLOOM, WE DO NOT JUST WEAR OUR HERITAGE — WE HELP WEAVE THE FUTURE OF VIKSIT BHARAT

The writer is the Union Minister of Textiles

PIC TALK



A peacock perches on a wall near Varun Sagar Lake in Ajmer district, Rajasthan. PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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SPACEX MOON CRASH OFFERS VALUABLE SCIENTIFIC RESEARCH OPPORTUNITY

An out-of-control rocket stage from Elon Musk's SpaceX has crashed into the lunar surface at a speed of nearly 8,960 km/h. According to NASA, the impact poses no threat to Earth.

The object was the upper stage of a SpaceX Falcon 9 rocket launched from Florida in January 2025 to carry three lunar landers from Japan and the United States into space. After completing its mission, the rocket stage remained in orbit, gradually drifting under the gravitational influence of the Earth, the Moon and the Sun before eventually colliding with the lunar surface.

While the incident may appear alarming, it presents a unique scientific opportunity. Unlike natural meteorites, whose size, speed and composition are usually

unknown before impact, scientists already possess detailed information about this rocket stage, including its weight, dimensions and velocity. This makes the event especially valuable for research.

By studying the newly formed crater and the dust ejected by the impact, researchers can gain deeper insights into the Moon's surface, impact processes and the geological evolution of celestial bodies. Such observations may also improve our understanding of how the Moon and the wider Solar System formed billions of years ago.

The incident highlights how even an unintended space event can contribute significantly to scientific knowledge and future lunar exploration.

YASHASWI BAIRAGI | UJJAIN

The attitude that shapes society



RAJYOGI BRAHMA KUMAR NIKUNJ JI



Attitude and behavior are woven into the fabric of daily life. Research has shown that individuals register an immediate and automatic reaction of good or bad towards everything they encounter in less than a second, even before they are aware of having formed an attitude. Most of the people hold complex relationships between attitudes and behavior that are further complicated by the social factors influencing both. This explains why two people placed in the same situation often respond very differently. The present state of the world, in which we live, is what it is because of certain systems viz. social, political, economic, religious and others, all these woven together into a complex structure, called society. These systems, in turn, are built on certain attitudes and values which various nations, communities or groups of people have come to acquire over a period of time. When these attitudes remain unquestioned for long, they slowly turn into rigid beliefs. These attitudes, in their turn, are based on the ideas, ideologies or beliefs which people have acquired, over a period of time, from others or have learnt by first-hand experience.

Many of these beliefs were relevant in a different era, but in a rapidly changing world, they now need re-examination. So, if we want to build a better world order, there is no way to it except through attitudinal change or the shift in values and that change or shift, as has been pointed out earlier, cannot take place unless certain age-old beliefs are changed. Let us, therefore, not forget that the improvement in the self, betterment of our relationships and the spirit of service of others would not be possible without Attitudinal Change, and in order to bring

about the attitudinal change, we have to give to the society a new, convincing and inspiring ideal and also the ideology necessary to achieve that ideal.

Most of our attitudes are built up in our family and hence the deterioration first starts in the family and then it penetrates into the society. So, in order to bring about a better world, we must inspire people to make a better family. Today, the family is disintegrating and so we find that there is a tendency of separatism and fragmentation all over the world, as a result of which a country like India that is known for its rich cultural heritage and family values is now witnessing more and more nuclear families as compared to joint families which acted as a strong support system for every member.

The criteria of every relationship today is "Give & Take". And when relationships become transactions, trust slowly erodes.

We must remember a fact that a man who is dissatisfied at home, would spread dissatisfaction and tension outside as well. So, before this erosion of values devastates us, we should seriously think about changing our attitudes and start building better families, for, better families would make a better world. So, don't wait too long, adjust your attitude right now. You'd be surprised how much you really can change the world just by changing your attitude.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a columnist

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Public statements must be backed by evidence

Media ownership is a matter of record

Political debate must not damage institutions

Apropos the recent statement by K Kavitha, the founder of Telangana Rakshana Sena, alleging that *The Pioneer* newspaper has been acquired for approximately ₹188 crore by KT Rama Rao or persons connected with the BRS, without being supported by verifiable evidence, has come as a surprise.

On the contrary, the publisher of the newspaper has outrightly rejected the allegations and said that no such transaction has taken place.

Political leaders have every right to raise questions, but statements regarding the ownership and independence of a longstanding media institution can impact the employees, readers, advertisers and business associates of the entity.

Public discourse must, therefore, remain factual and responsible. Either credible evidence must be placed in the public domain or the statement should be formally clarified.

Unverified allegations when repeatedly circulated through digital platforms can cause lasting reputational and commercial damage more so when such statements are made to settle political scores.

The controversy arising out of K Kavitha's reported statement regarding the ownership of *The Pioneer* highlights the need for responsibility in political communications. The statement that the newspaper has been purchased for ₹188 crore has been categorically denied by the publisher.

The ownership and shareholding of a company are matters capable of verification through official records. Instead of allowing speculation to spread through social media, the parties concerned should place authentic documents before the public. Unsupported claims can undermine the credibility of both political leaders and media organisations.

Freedom of expression is essential but it must be accompanied by accountability, particularly when the statement has the potential to affect the reputation, editorial independence and commercial interests of a newspaper. Also, to raise questions about bias in a media organisation is a serious concern and must be corroborated by facts as it threatens freedom of Press. The TRS leader must come clean in her allegations, or else the reputation of over an 150-year-old publication is bound to be tarnished in a game of political one-upmanship.

As a vivid *The Pioneer* reader for generations, the statement of K Kavitha that the newspaper was taken over by KT Rama Rao or BRS came as a shock recently. Having being based out of Allahabad, Lucknow and New Delhi, the acquisition claims were absorbed with a pinch of salt.

However, the newspaper's prompt rejection of the claim came as a pleasant surprise.

Political leaders make statements to settle political scores. But Kavitha's statement raising doubts over the credibility of a brand which has lasted over 165 years is a matter of serious concern.

By simply alleging that a change of ownership would undermine freedom of press is a serious charge. The Telengana leader must provide evidence substantiating her sale remarks against the newspaper or retract her statement with an apology. Such unfounded statements on the social media impacts the business entity severely, affecting its finances and credibility both.

Leaders must refrain from dragging business entities into their political manoeuvres without any evidence and stoip using social media to further their intentional bias.

SANJAY MISHRA | NEW DELHI

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ASHOK KUMAR | LUCKNOW

Why the Cauvery dispute needs science, trust and ecological renewal

The immediate crisis may be managed through compliance and dialogue, but lasting peace in the Cauvery basin will require far more than court orders. It demands transparent, science-based water management, real-time hydrological data, climate-responsive water allocation mechanisms, and, above all, the restoration of forests



BK SINGH

'The dispute between Karnataka and Tamil Nadu over the sharing of Cauvery water is a hundred years old. The Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) ordered Karnataka on 28 July to release 3,500 cusecs of water every day for fifteen days. Biligundlu, a water-measuring station in Tamil Nadu, records the outflow from Karnataka. The CWMA was constituted by the Supreme Court in 2018 to oversee the implementation of the Cauvery Tribunal Award. The long-pending dispute was resolved by the Supreme Court in 2018, allocating 404.25 TMC to Tamil Nadu, 284.75 TMC to Karnataka, 30 TMC to Kerala and 7 TMC to Puducherry. In the same order, the Supreme Court also recognised 740 TMC per year as the drinking water requirement for Bengaluru.

Due to deficient rainfall during June and July this year, Karnataka's reservoirs were 65.6% below the 30-year average level by the end of July. Karnataka moved the CWMA again, arguing that releasing water at this stage would jeopardise the water supply required for drinking purposes up to June 2027. The State argued that Tamil Nadu had already benefited from the earlier releases of water and would soon receive the North-East Monsoon. It further added that maintaining a flow of 3,500 cusecs would require a release of 7,000 cusecs from the upper reservoirs, considering the dry conditions of the riverbeds and transmission losses. Tamil Nadu opposed the move and charged Karnataka with not sharing the distress-sharing formula. The CWMA rejected Karnataka's submission and directed it to continue releasing water according to the 28 July order. However, due to the sudden revival of the monsoon in early August, the four reservoirs, namely Krishna Raj Sagar, Hemavati, Kabini and Harangi, in the Cauvery basin are receiving an inflow of 81,000 cusecs of water a day. In view of this, the Karnataka Government conducted a meeting of representatives of all political parties and decided to comply with the direction of the CWMA. Despite this, Tamil Nadu is knocking on the doors of the Supreme Court.

The overall drought situation in Karnataka is quite severe. Mandya farmers are protesting over water for agricultural crops. Bengaluru is totally dependent on Cauvery water. Karnataka must present relevant data on the drought to the Central Government, concerned ministries and authorities. Furthermore, MPs from Karnataka should also raise the issue in Parliament. The Government should aggressively bring the data into the public domain and use back-channel communication to explain the prevailing hydrological conditions within the bureaucracy. A bilateral meeting between the Chief Ministers of the two states would be a welcome step, but it has been put off amid escalating tensions over the Cauvery water-sharing dispute. It is hoped that it materialises soon.

The crisis in Cauvery water sharing has been caused by a steep rainfall deficit in the catchment during the first two months of the south-west monsoon this year. The IMD and WMO have forecast a Super El Niño, which may impact the rainfall pattern from August/September onwards; however, the rainfall deficit during June and July is attributed to local weather conditions. The IMD's forecast covered all regions of the country, but the Western Ghats region of peninsular India has registered a greater rainfall deficit compared with other parts of the country. However, the WMO's latest update predicted the possibility of a positive Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD), which could offset the impact of El Niño.

El Niño is a climatic pattern involving the warming of surface waters in the central and eastern tropical Pacific and is linked with a weak monsoon and relatively harsher summers. The IOD is governed by the difference in sea surface temperature between the western and eastern tropical Indian Ocean. A positive IOD helps form stronger monsoon winds and can partly nullify the influence of El Niño.

The Cauvery water dispute between Tamil Nadu and Karnataka is a flashpoint in distress years, when reservoir levels are low and riverbeds are dry. In this opinion piece, let me bring out some short-term and some long-term solutions to deal with the issue.

Hydrologists are of the view that the principle behind sharing water in distress years is to distribute the shortfall proportionately between the states. In other



words, the water received in the basin should be shared proportionately among all stakeholders. The principle is accepted by all, but the difficulty arises when stakeholders question the quantity of the rainfall deficit, reservoir storage, inflows, drinking water requirements, or any other data presented by the other side. A third-party assessment of the data may be acceptable to both sides.

Experts have flagged genuine issues and have called for updated studies on siltation in major reservoirs, accurate live storage of water, rainfall, and transparent real-time hydrological data. Any formula worked out on the basis of these data will inspire greater confidence among stakeholders and would be more acceptable. They also add that climate variability has made droughts more frequent. The allocations designed on a monthly schedule and based on a normal monsoon do not work in distress situations. The allocations must be made dynamic and should depend on science-based temporal and spatial data, certified by a third party.

Among the several reservoirs in the Cauvery basin, Krishna Raj Sagar, Harangi, Hemavati and Kabini are the main ones, where gates are opened to release water to Tamil Nadu. The catchments of these reservoirs were heavily forested, but, with the passage of time, anthropogenic pressures led to the degradation of forests in the catchments. As a result, large quantities of silt come down through streams and tributaries and get deposited in the reservoirs. The rate of siltation is directly proportional to the loss of tree cover in the catchments. Frequent desiltation of the reservoirs is not practical, as dewatering of reservoirs during the summer season is often avoided to save summer crops. A high proportion of the dead storage in the reservoirs contains silt. Continuous deforestation in the catchments will have to be prevented so that their water-holding capacity is not compromised.

The current tension between the two states can be resolved by exchanging authentic data, but the long-term solution can come only by preserving the landscape and avoiding changes in the land-use pattern of the catchments. The Cauvery catchments in Karnataka comprise good-quality forests as well as shola forests interspersed with grasslands. Apart from the legal and illegal cutting of trees to satisfy different interests, such as land grabbing and the felling of valuable trees, the grasslands are set on fire every year. Although the fire does not enter the sholas, it scorches all around their periphery. Every year, the sholas shrink, and so does their capacity to hold water.

The roots of trees in the sholas act like a sponge and store water during the rainy season. A stream originates from every patch of shola, carrying water downhill to join larger streams and tributaries before finally flowing into rivers. It is these rivers that feed water to the reservoirs. The flow of water in streams originating from the sholas continues even after the end of the rainy season, confirming that the water remains stored in the roots of the trees. As the sholas shrink, the summer flow in the streams depletes. A special drive must be undertaken to prevent fires and conserve the sholas, as well as all other forests in the river catchments.

This year's drought has also triggered a war of words between the political parties of the two states. The Karnataka Government is set to revive its Mekedatu Project on the River Cauvery, planned to solve the drinking water problem of Bengaluru city. Tamil Nadu opposes the project, fearing that its share of Cauvery water would decline in future distress years. In my opinion, this project would be an environmental disaster, as 5,000 hectares of dry deciduous forests would have to be sacrificed. The loss of forests would make wildlife homeless and increase human-wildlife conflict. The population density of elephants in the area is quite high; elephants straying into villages would trample people and damage crops, creating an irreversible situation.

The writer is the retired Head of the Forest Force, Karnataka

Green hydrogen needs a climate finance architecture



RIA SINHA

Bank of India advances its climate risk framework and financial institutions increasingly integrate climate considerations into lending decisions, the focus must now shift from managing climate-related financial risks to building the institutional architecture that enables climate investments themselves.

This explains an important paradox in India's energy transition. Commercial banks readily finance utility-scale renewable energy (RE) projects, yet green hydrogen, battery energy storage and industrial decarbonisation projects continue to struggle to achieve financial closure. The conventional explanation is that banks remain overly risk-averse. That diagnosis, however, mistakes the symptom for the problem.

Banks are not unwilling to finance climate technologies; they are unwilling to finance risks they cannot adequately assess or price. A 500 MW solar park today can comfortably secure long-tenor debt, whereas an equally ambitious green hydrogen project often struggles to attract financing. The difference lies less in the technology than in the predictability of future cash flows. Competitive auctions, standardised power purchase agreements, payment security mechanisms, declining technology costs and experienced developers created stable revenue streams that lenders could underwrite with confidence.

Green hydrogen presents a fundamentally different proposition.

Despite the NGHM and significant public support, lenders continue to confront four unanswered questions: Who will purchase green hydrogen? At what price? Under what contractual arrangements? And for how long?

Similar uncertainties confront battery energy storage, where revenues depend on evolving ancillary service markets and capacity payments, and industrial decarbonisation projects, where returns often arise from avoided costs rather than dedicated revenue streams. These sectors are commercially promising, but they have not yet developed the predictable revenue models that conventional project finance requires. These are not merely financing constraints. They are bankability constraints.

This distinction fundamentally changes the policy response. If capital scarcity were the principal challenge, mobilising larger climate funds or attracting additional international finance would be sufficient. But where projects lack revenue certainty, investable risk profiles and mature market structures, additional liquidity alone is unlikely to unlock commercial investment. International experience points in a different direction. Germany's Carbon Contracts for Difference (CfDs) and H2Global programme reduce market risk by providing long-term revenue certainty for green hydrogen and industrial decarbonisation. The UK's Green Investment Bank demonstrated how specialised public institutions can crowd in private capital into commercially nascent sectors. The common thread across these models is institutions designed to convert uncertainty into investable opportunities. India's next challenge is building the institutional architecture that makes emerging climate technologies bankable. Recent research by the Chintan Research Foundation proposes a Climate Finance Architecture Framework in which emerging sectors become investment-grade only when risks are systematically reduced as projects mature.

The first stage is pipeline creation. Institutions such as MNRE, SECI and state governments should move beyond production incentives towards project preparation facilities, standardised long-term hydrogen purchase agreements, industrial demand aggregation and common infrastructure within hydrogen hubs to create a pipeline of investment-ready projects with predictable contractual arrangements.

The second stage is early-stage risk absorption. Institutions such as the National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF), sovereign-backed climate funds and multi-lateral development banks should establish platform-level investment vehicles capable of absorbing technology, construction and market risks across diversified portfolios rather than financing individual projects. Such platforms can anchor private investment by improving risk allocation.

The third stage is commercial debt mobilisation. Once project risks begin to decline, specialised lenders such as IREDA and REC, together with commercial banks, should provide long-tenor debt supported by blended finance structures, partial credit guarantees and risk-sharing facilities. Public finance should complement, and not replace, commercial capital by addressing risks that private lenders cannot efficiently bear.

The fourth stage is financial intermediation. India requires specialised intermediaries capable of aggregating projects, warehousing assets, standardising documentation and refinancing operational portfolios. Individual green hydrogen projects may remain too small or risky for institutional investors, but diversified portfolios can evolve into investment-grade assets capable of attracting pension funds, insurance companies and global climate investors.

The final stage is capital recycling. Regulators, capital markets and institutional investors must facilitate green bonds, securitisation, InvITs and other market-based instruments that enable mature assets to be transferred from bank balance sheets to long-term investors. Recycling capital is essential if commercial banks are to finance successive waves of climate investments without stretching their balance sheets.

India's renewable energy sector offers an important lesson. Solar parks did not become bankable because banks suddenly became more willing to lend. They became bankable because institutions progressively allocated risks, standardised market practices and created financing mechanisms aligned with lenders' risk appetite.

Green hydrogen now demands the same institutional evolution. India's leadership in the next generation of clean technologies will ultimately depend not only on technological innovation or larger financial commitments, but on whether its financial institutions evolve as rapidly as its energy ambitions. The next chapter of India's energy transition will therefore be written not by capital alone, but by a Climate Finance Architecture Framework capable of systematically converting technological promise into investable infrastructure.



The writer is a Senior Research Consultant at the Centre for Climate Change and Energy Efficiency, Chintan Research Foundation

Beyond ritual: Sawan as a catalyst for environmental responsibility



GAURAV KUMAR SHARMA

When the first monsoon clouds gather over the Himalayas and the fragrance of rain rises from the earth, something stirs deep within India's collective memory. Sawan does not merely announce the arrival of a new season; it awakens an ancient relationship between faith and nature. Rivers begin to swell, forests regain their emerald hues, and the land breathes again after months of scorching heat. It is no coincidence that this sacred month is dedicated to Lord Shiva, who bears the Ganga in His matted locks, dwells amidst the Himalayas, and embodies the eternal harmony between humanity and the natural world. To worship Lord Shiva has always been to honour the rivers, mountains, forests, and every form of life that surrounds Him. Perhaps that is Sawan's deepest message—that devotion reaches its highest expression when it inspires responsibility towards the very creation Lord Shiva represents.

This spirit comes alive in the Kanwar Yatra. Millions of devotees undertake the pilgrimage carrying the sacred Ganga jal, transforming individual faith into a remarkable expression of discipline, equality, and collective service. Along the route, citizens, voluntary organisations, and temples establish bhandaras, medical camps, and resting facilities, while local administrations ensure sanitation, healthcare, traffic management, and public safety. Together, they create one of the world's largest examples of community participation inspired by faith. The Bhagavad Gita captures the essence of this spirit through Lord Krishna's timeless teaching—Karmanye vadhikaraste ma phaleshu kadachana—that duty performed without expectation of reward is itself an act of worship. Offering water to a weary pilgrim, keeping the pilgrimage route clean, protecting a river, or planting a tree are not separate from devotion; they are devotion in action.

India's environmental consciousness is deeply rooted in its civilisational heritage. The Vedas revere rivers as mothers and forests as sacred spaces of learning.

The concept of the Panchamahabhuta—earth, water, fire, air, and space—reflects an ancient understanding that humanity and nature are inseparable. The Ramayana portrays forests as landscapes of wisdom and coexistence, while the

cipline, equality, and collective service. Along the route, citizens, voluntary organisations, and temples establish bhandaras, medical camps, and resting facilities, while local administrations ensure sanitation, healthcare, traffic management, and public safety. Together, they create one of the world's largest examples of community participation inspired by faith. The Bhagavad Gita captures the essence of this spirit through Lord Krishna's timeless teaching—Karmanye vadhikaraste ma phaleshu kadachana—that duty performed without expectation of reward is itself an act of worship. Offering water to a weary pilgrim, keeping the pilgrimage route clean, protecting a river, or planting a tree are not separate from devotion; they are devotion in action.

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Mahabharata reminds us that dharma sustains the balance of the world. Long before sustainability entered global discourse, Indian thought had already recognised that human well-being depends upon ecological harmony.

Today, this timeless wisdom finds contemporary expression in Mission LiFE (Lifestyle for Environment), which encourages environmentally conscious choices through everyday behaviour.

Sawan offers an ideal opportunity to translate that philosophy into practice. An inspiring example already exists in Lucknow's Green Bada Mangal initiative, which has shown how a

change tradition; they strengthen it by reflecting the timeless Indian ethos of living in harmony with nature, and they complement other national initiatives such as the Swachh Bharat Mission and Namami Gange, which have reinforced cleanliness, responsible waste management, and river conservation through active public participation. Their lasting success lies in the partnership between government, communities, and citizens, demonstrating that sustainability becomes truly transformative when it evolves into a people's movement.

One of Sawan's greatest strengths is its scale.

A reusable bottle instead of a disposable one, a cloth bag replacing plastic, a sapling planted along a pilgrimage route, or a wrapper picked up instead of ignored may appear small. Yet, multiplied by millions of devotees, these simple acts reduce waste, protect biodiversity, and preserve the sanctity of pilgrimage routes. Environmental conservation succeeds best when it becomes part of culture rather than compulsion, and Sawan provides precisely that opportunity.

As another Sawan unfolds, it offers an opportunity to every stakeholder—devotees, Kanwariyas, temple committees, volunteers, community organisations, local administrations, and governments—to make one of the world's largest annual pilgrimages one of its most sustainable as well. Cleaner pilgrimage routes, environmentally responsible bhandaras, plastic-free public spaces, and active citizen participation are not departures from tradition; they are a reaffirmation of the values that have always defined it. This Sawan, let every prayer be accompanied by a conscious act of conservation, every bhandara become an example of sustainable seva, and every Kanwariya an ambassador for nature. Among the finest offerings we can make to Lord Shiva is the resolve to leave behind cleaner rivers, healthier forests, and a greener India for generations to come. In serving nature, we honour Lord Shiva—not only in faith, but in action.

The writer is a Media and Communication Officer with the Press Information Bureau, Government of India



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Order Order

SC stays arrest of Abhishek Banerjee’s aide Sumit Roy in Salboni land-grabbing case

The Supreme Court on Thursday stayed the arrest of Sumit Roy, Personal Assistant to Trinamool Congress MP Abhishek Banerjee, in connection with the Salboni land-grabbing case. The top court, however, directed him to cooperate fully with the ongoing investigation. On August 3, the Calcutta High Court rejected the anticipatory bail plea of Roy in connection with the alleged Government land fraud case being investigated by the Salboni Police.

The case was registered under penal provisions relating to cheating, criminal breach of trust, forgery, use of forged documents and criminal conspiracy.

On Thursday, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohna took note of submissions of senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for Roy, in the case and protected him from any coercive action.

“The petitioner to fully cooperate with the ongoing investigation. He should not be accompanied by any advocate or any other person. He shall remain available for any investigation from 10:00 am to 6:00 pm. with the usual breaks. However, his arrest will remain stayed,” the bench ordered. Sankaranarayanan said that his client had already been granted anticipatory bail by the Calcutta High Court in another case relating to the alleged cash-for-jobs scam. He also said that the FIR in the present case was registered only after the new Government assumed office.

(PTI)

SC refuses to relax bail conditions of accused Ashish



The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to further relax the bail conditions of Ashish Mishra, the prime accused in the 2021 Lakhimpur Kheri violence case.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana dismissed Mishra's application seeking relaxation of his bail conditions and permitting him to visit his native place to take part in family functions.

The counsel for Mishra said that due to the existing restrictions, he is unable to attend family functions, including his daughters' birthday celebrations.

“There is no ground to entertain this prayer at this stage. The application is dismissed,” the CJI said.

During the hearing, advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for victim farmers, expressed concern over the manner in which the trial was being conducted, alleging that several crucial witnesses, including eyewitnesses, were being dropped because of the speed at which the proceedings were being carried out.

“One of the problems is the manner in which the trial is proceeding. Many of the critical witnesses have been given up because of the speed and haste with which the trial is being conducted. They are summoned for the very next day, and if they do not appear the next day, they are given up,” he said. Bhushan said he intended to file an application highlighting these concerns. The CJI said such grievances should first be raised before the trial court.

(PTI)

HC refuses to interfere with criminal proceedings against doctor over minor’s abortion

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has refused to interfere with the criminal proceedings against a doctor for allegedly illegally terminating a 16-year-old girl's six-week pregnancy and failing to report the matter to the authorities.

While the petitioner-doctor claimed that the minor's age at the time of abortion was stated to be 20 years and she consented to the procedure, Justice Purushendra Kumar Kaurav underscored that under the law, age has to be “ascertained and recorded”, and “not merely accepted on an unverified oral representation”.

Justice Kaurav held that the Medical Termination of Pregnancy (MTP) Act provides that a minor is incapable of



independently consenting to termination and her pregnancy cannot be medically terminated without the guardian's consent in writing.

“A registered medical practitioner performing an invasive procedure that the MTP Act itself conditions on the patient's age is not absolved of the obligation to seek some documentary anchor for that age merely because an escort volunteers a figure. The entire statutory architecture exam-



SC asks petitioners seeking NTA reforms to file replies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday asked petitioners, including a doctors' association, to file their replies to the Centre's affidavit, which said that the migration of the NEET (UG) examination from the pen-and-paper mode to a computer-based mode on the pattern of JEE (Mains and Advanced), is under active consideration.



A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe said that the court will take up the matter on August 19 and the petitioners can file their replies to the counter-affidavit filed by the Centre.

Advocate Tanvi Dubey, appearing for the Federation of All India Medical Association (FAIMA), informed the bench that in case there is any plan for transition to a computer-based model, then the same should be done at the earliest since the students' preparation right now was driven by the pen-and-paper mode.

The bench said that it would consider everything and asked the parties to file their replies and suggestions.

Senior advocate Pijush Kanti Roy and advocate Satyam Singh Rajput appeared for RJD MP Sudhakar Singh, who has sought reforms in the National Testing Agency (NTA).

In its affidavit, the Centre said in respect of NEET (UG), the migration from the pen-and-paper mode to a computer-based mode, whether in a single-stage or a two-stage examination on the pattern of the Joint Entrance Examination (Mains and Advanced), is presently under active consideration by all stakeholders.

“The Union of India respectfully submits that the final approach will be adopted after considering, and with the benefit of, the recommendations of the High-Powered Task Force under the chairmanship of Nandan Nilekani,” the composition

of the task force, with domain expertise drawn from technology, space, intelligence, academia and public administration, ensures a rigorous and holistic examination of the technological, security, equity, infrastructure and pedagogic dimensions of the transition,” it had said.

The Government further said it has undertaken a comprehensive overhaul of the conduct of the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) to eliminate paper leaks and systemic failures.

The affidavit was filed in response to the apex court's May 29 direction asking the Union Government to explain how future NEET examinations would be conducted and how regulatory authorities would build

and retain institutional memory to improve examination processes over successive years.

The Centre had said that Parliament has further strengthened the legal framework against examination fraud through the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Act, 2026, building on the 2024 law that criminalised question paper leaks, impersonation, tampering with computer systems and other examination-related offences.

One of the pleas sought a direction to replace or restructure the NTA, which is responsible for conducting NEET-UG, with a robust and autonomous body to conduct the medical entrance examination.

On May 12, the NTA cancelled NEET-UG, held on May 3, amid allegations of paper leak. The retest was held on June 21. The paper leak allegations are under investigation by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI).

After questions of NEET-UG were allegedly leaked in 2024, the top court had refused to cancel the test, but passed various directions aimed at tackling paper leaks and also a criterion for cancelling public exams.

HC treats WhatsApp messages as dying declaration in suicide case, denies bail to trio

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Indore

The Madhya Pradesh High Court has termed WhatsApp messages found on the mobile phone of a 25-year-old tribal man “prima facie crucial dying declaration” in a suicide abetment case, refusing to grant bail to three accused persons.

Justice Jai Kumar Pillai from the HC's Indore bench upheld the order of the Special Judge (Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act) of Dhar district on July 27, rejecting the bail pleas of the

accused, and dismissed their appeals against it.

The prosecution told the high court that Santosh, alias Lakhna Ausari, hanged himself due to harassment, abuse, humiliation, and death threats allegedly received from Karan Jat, Dharmendra Jat, and Umesh Jat over a dispute concerning an agricultural land.

According to the prosecution, the investigation showed that on May 7, before his death, Ausari had sent WhatsApp messages to his father.

The high court noted, “A critical piece of evidence pro-



duced by the prosecution is the Panchnama related to the deceased's mobile phone. The record reflects that shortly before his death, the deceased sent three WhatsApp messages to his father's mobile number.”

The single-judge bench said that this electronic evidence serves as “a crucial prima facie dying declaration”, explicitly naming the appellants. The court said, “Furthermore, the statements of the deceased's father,

Bhuralal Ausari, and brother, Bhima Ausari, recorded during the investigation, corroborate the prosecution's narrative. Both witnesses have categorically stated that the appellants systematically threatened, abused, and insulted the deceased over an old agricultural land dispute, subjecting him to continuous death threats which allegedly drove him to end his life.”

The counsel for the accused argued that the three had no connection with Ausari's suicide and that they had been implicated in the case due to an old rivalry. However, the prosecution

objected to the bail pleas, citing the material found during the investigation and the nature of the allegations.

After considering the arguments of both sides, the high court said Ausari specifically named the accused in the WhatsApp messages that he sent before his death. It also noted that the statements of his immediate family members point to “continuous harassment”.

“The evidentiary defences and grounds raised by the appellants do not inspire sufficient confidence to grant the relief of bail at this stage,” the HC said.

SC hints probe against ED officer may be shifted to central agency

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday hinted that it may transfer the probe into a Tamil Nadu Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption bribery case against Enforcement Directorate (ED) officer Ankit Tiwari to a central investigating agency.

The top court, however, made it clear that it is not inclined to vacate the stay on the state's proceedings in the case.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was hearing a petition filed by the Enforcement Directorate in 2024 seeking transfer of the investigation from the Tamil Nadu Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) to the CBI. In January 2024, the bench



stayed further proceedings in the FIR registered by the Tamil Nadu agency.

During the brief hearing, senior advocate Guru Krishna Kumar, appearing for Tamil Nadu, told the bench that the state filed an application seeking vacation of the interim stay. “Further proceedings against an ED officer were stayed. We have sought a vacation of the stay,” the senior lawyer said.

The state agency alleged that the officer was caught

“red-handed” and that the investigation should be allowed to proceed.

The bench, however, suggested that instead of permitting the state agency to continue the probe, the investigation could be entrusted to another central investigating agency. “Or, we hand over the investigation to some central agency,” the CJI said. The bench said it was not inclined to lift the interim protection granted earlier. “We are not going to vacate the stay. We will decide the main case itself,” the CJI said.

“The State is fighting against the ED tooth and nail. The question is who should believe the allegations. If the allegations are correct, let them be investigated by a central agency. Not the ED, but another,” the CJI said. The hearing on the plea of the ED was adjourned.

SC allows Asaram to engage trained care taker of his choice, no interim bail

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday denied interim bail as of now to self-styled godman Asaram, who is serving life sentence in a 2013 case of sexually assaulting a minor, but allowed him to engage a trained caretaker of his choice for round-the-clock assistance.

A bench of Justices M M Sundresh and PB Varale kept the plea filed by Asaram, seeking interim bail on health grounds, pending while granting him liberty to mention his case if his health deteriorates.

During the hearing, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta submitted that Asaram has suppressed from the court that his counsel moved an application for parole.

The counsel for Asaram



said the parole was filed much earlier and that it was not granted on health grounds.

The Rajasthan High Court had earlier granted 20-day parole to Asaram, saying the state Government failed to justify its decision to reject his parole application. The HC had granted relief to the 85-year-old Asaram, lodged in Jodhpur Central Jail, taking note of the duration of his incarceration and his conduct during earlier periods of interim

release. The top court was earlier informed that experts from AIIMS have suggested that Asaram does not require hospitalisation but needs round-the-clock medical assistance.

On July 21, the apex court had asked AIIMS to constitute a medical board to assess Asaram's condition.

The Rajasthan High Court on May 27 upheld the conviction and life sentence awarded to Asaram in a case of rape of a minor in 2013.

Rani Kapur-Priya Kapur dispute: SC hopeful that matter may be resolved amicably

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Noting that mediation is proceeding “quite satisfactorily,” the Supreme Court on Thursday said it was “hopeful” that the dispute between late industrialist Sunjay Kapur's mother Rani Kapur and his wife Priya Kapur over the family trust may be resolved amicably.

A bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and K Vindod Chandran took note of the preliminary mediation report filed by the mediator.

“We take notice that the mediation proceedings so far have been conducted over 6 sessions. The Mediator has interacted with all members of the family. We are happy to note that the mediation is proceeding quite satisfacto-

rily. We are happy to note that parties are cooperating,” the bench said.

The top court also noted that the mediator has made a request to allow time for mediation till November 2.

“...parties should go before the mediator with open mind and heart and see to it they don't get dragged in a long drawn litigation. Let the mediation proceed, we shall wait for one more report,” the bench said.

In its order, the apex court also directed that the fees of the mediator shall be paid from the RK Family Trust and there should not be any further debate in this regard.

“If the mediation fails, we will allow you all to proceed in accordance with law. But don't allow that day to come,” the bench told the parties.



The top court had earlier appointed former Chief Justice of India DY Chandrachud to act as a mediator in the dispute.

On April 27, the top court sought a response from Priya Kapur and others on a lawsuit by Sanjay Kapur's mother seeking directions to declare the family trust “null and void.” During the hearing, the SC also asked the parties to explore medi-

ation to resolve the dispute over the family trust.

The 80-year-old Rani Kapur's plea alleges that the trust, which was constituted in her name in October 2017, was a product of “forged, fabricated and fraudulent” documents.

The legal proceedings over control of the estate and assets are pending before the Delhi High Court, and the petition before the top court seeks a status quo on alienation of all the properties of the trust.

In the lawsuit, Rani Kapur has sought a direction to permanently restrain the defendants — her daughter-in-law Priya Kapur and others, including grandchildren — from utilising or acting in furtherance of the RK Family Trust in any manner whatsoever.

Allahabad HC quashes remand order against man



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has quashed the remand order against a petitioner and directed his release upon furnishing a bond, stating that he was not provided the grounds at the time of his arrest. The bench comprising Justices J J Munir and Tarun Saxena also criticised the police's approach to constitutional safeguards.

It observed that they have “traditionally paid scant regard” to the requirements of Article 22(1) of the Constitution, which makes it mandatory for the police to provide grounds of arrest to the detainee, and often fail to appreciate the significance of fundamental rights when exercising the power of arrest.

The high court also directed the Sessions Judge in Sambhal to ensure that magistrates under his administrative control do not authorise police or judicial remand mechanically on printed pro formas and do not remand an accused

without first ascertaining that the constitutional requirement of communicating the grounds of arrest has been complied with.

The court said police officers often fail to understand that there are always two sides to a fact or an allegation regarding an offence, and remain partisan, looking at just one side.

It further observed that police training bereft of knowledge of the law deprives policemen of the forensic eye to understand legal implications, resulting in a continuing “tug of war” between judicial orders safeguarding individual liberty and “dogged breaches by the police”.

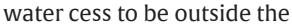
“This arrest memo does not carry grounds of arrest, but reasons of arrest (of petitioner Rakesh). The reasons have already been distinguished from grounds by the Supreme Court in the Prabir Purkayastha case. There is absolutely no ground mentioned in the memo of arrest,” the court observed in its judgment dated July 27.

WWW.i-exceed.com

The consolidated net profit was at ₹3,630.58 crore in the quarter ended on June 30, 2025, the company said in a regulatory filing on Wednesday. The company's total income, however, rose to ₹11,696.72 crore in the quarter from ₹11,444.42 crore in the same period a year ago. (PTI)

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | AUGUST 7, 2026

The Committee on Public Undertakings, in its 31st report tabled in the Parliament, noted that several state governments have modified agreements with public sector hydroelectric company NHPC to include revised demand for free power, reassessment of SGST waivers and the application of water cess for hydroelec-



al ministry said it remains committed to ensuring uninterrupted adequate coal supply to all users, particularly the power sector, to support the nation's growing energy needs.

A parliamentary panel on Thursday suggested the power ministry to devise a viable water cess framework for hydroelectric projects in the country that are mutually agreeable between the Central and State Governments.

The Committee on Public Undertakings, in its 31st report tabled in the Parliament, noted that several state governments have modified agreements with public sector hydroelectric company NHPCL to include revised demand for free power, reassessment of SGST waivers and the application of water cess for hydroelec-

The Ministry of Power, in its presentation before the Committee, said that water cess, which adjusts tariffs by 60-70 paise per unit, should not be applied, as water

On Wednesday, the rupee gained 20 paise to settle at 95.08 against the US dollar. Indian Rupee declined today on a slight bounce in the US Dollar index and modest gains in the US treasury yields.

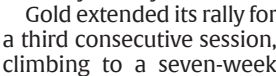
benchmark hit a high of 24,677.05 and a low of 24,604.15.

Among other changes, SEBI has proposed extending certain website disclosure requirements for clearing corporations to all segments. These include disclosures

SEBI noted that clearing corporations retain DP registrations mainly for establishing connectivity with depositories for clearing and settlement activities and do not undertake retail client transactions like regular DPs.

The regulator has also proposed deleting or relocating provisions relating to client code modification, order-level checks, dynamic price bands and base minimum capital as these are already covered elsewhere in the regulatory framework.

"It (micro-housing loan business) has already started; now, since the policy and training are in place, I think it should start. Safely by the end of the year, AUM of this business could be around ₹100 crore," Ajai Kumar Shukla, managing director and chief executive officer of PNB Housing Finance, told PTI in an interview.



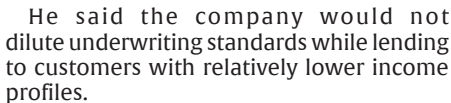
LKP Securities, investors will closely track the US non-farm payrolls and unemployment data due on Friday, as the releases are expected to play a crucial role in shaping expectations for the Federal Reserve's interest rate outlook.

Besides, it suggested the power ministry to develop a dedicated policy framework to grow the hydro and PSP (pumped hydro storage project) contractor ecosystem, including pre-qualifica-

Also, NHPC should accord the highest strategic priority to its 20,000 MW pumped storage project pipeline, the panel said, adding that the power ministry should provide dedicated facilitation, including expedited site allotments, clearance prioritization and off-take guarantee mechanisms to ensure that national pumped storage project targets are met in line with grid stability requirements.

Power Grid, Tata Consultancy Services, InterGlobe Aviation and Mahindra & Mahindra were among the laggards.

"Indian equity markets ended the session on a mixed note, with the benchmark indices displaying a notable performance divergence even as investor sentiment remained cautiously constructive amid continued optimism over a potential diplomatic resolution to the Middle East conflict," Hariselvan Radhakrishnan, Founder & CEO of HST Wealth, a Research Analyst firm, said.



"We will not compromise underwriting standards. Your valuation process, legal process, underwriting process and personal discussion process will remain intact," he added.

China protests Japan’s defence white paper

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

China has lodged a “serious diplomatic” protest with Japan over its latest defence white paper, which portrayed Beijing as Tokyo’s “greatest strategic challenge” and made “brazen comments” on Taiwan, further escalating tensions between the two countries.

“The white paper once again targeted China with groundless accusations, rehearsing the so-called ‘China threat’ and grossly interfering in China’s internal affairs with brazen comments on China’s Taiwan region,” Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jing said.

“We deplore and firmly reject this, and have lodged serious representations with Japan,” he said while answering questions over Japan’s new defence white paper.

Defending recurring military



drills around Taiwan, which China claims as part of its territory, Lin said, “Taiwan is an inalienable part of China’s territory. The Taiwan question is entirely China’s internal affair. How to resolve it is a matter for the Chinese ourselves and

Japan is in no place to interfere.” About disputed islands in the East China Sea, he said, “Diaoyu Dao and its affiliated islands have been China’s territory since ancient times.” The islands, called Senkaku by Japan and Diaoyu Dao by China,

are controlled by Tokyo. The Chinese coast guard periodically conducts patrols around them to assert Beijing’s sovereignty.

The white paper approved by Japan’s cabinet said China’s growing military actions are Japan’s top security challenge and “must be addressed through overall national strength and cooperation with allies and like-minded nations.”

The nearly 600-page white paper contained a detailed assessment of the increasingly volatile regional security environment.

Coinciding with the release of the white paper, Japan showcased its new anti-ship missile, with a range of about 1,000 km. The missile test brings Tokyo a step closer to fielding an indigenous family of long-range stand-off missiles that could be deployed from the land, sea and

air, the Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post reported.

In his preface to the white paper, Japanese Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi hoped that it would “deepen the public’s understanding of Japan’s defence and security, and serve as an opportunity for people to reflect on how security is linked to the future of every citizen.”

“As the security environment rapidly intensifies, what is needed now is to enhance resilience to crises across the entire Indo-Pacific region,” Koizumi wrote, pledging to build and expand “a multi-layered network of allies and like-minded nations, and increase interconnectivity in all aspects, including training, troop deployment, equipment and industrial infrastructure, to improve deterrence across the region.” (PTI)



Visitors pray in front of the cenotaph dedicated to the victims of the atomic bombing ahead of a ceremony to mark the anniversary of the bombing at the Hiroshima Peace Memorial Park in Hiroshima, western Japan (AP)

Health workers protest unpaid wages at Congo Ebola epicentre

CONSTANT SAME BAGALWA ■ Bunia

Dozens of health workers working at the epicentre of Congo’s Ebola outbreak staged protests on Thursday to demand payment for their wages, abandoning several health facilities even as aid workers warn that the world’s fastest-growing outbreak of the disease is spreading at an alarming rate.

The health workers are protesting at the governor’s office in Bunia, the capital of Ituri province, which accounts for nearly 90 per cent of the Ebola cases in the country. They are the latest group to walk off their jobs since protests over pay issues began weeks ago.

The health workers, including nurses providing critical care to Ebola patients, said they haven’t received wages and bonuses for their work fighting Ebola since the outbreak was declared in mid-May. “With this way of managing things, Ebola will not end in this province.

We ask the authorities to get involved at all levels so that a solution is found quickly,” said Edouige Makosi, one of the protesters. (AP)



Bangladesh to hold presidential election on August 20: EC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dhaka

Bangladesh’s presidential election will be held on August 20, the Election Commission announced on Thursday, two weeks after President Mohammed Shahabuddin resigned on health grounds before completing his five-year term.

Shahabuddin, 76, was a longtime ally of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina. “Chief Election Commissioner AMM Nasir Uddin has finalised the dates in consultation with (acting parliamentary) Speaker Kayser Kamal,” the Election Commission’s senior secretary Akhtar Ahmed told reporters.

In line with the Constitution, the parliament members elect the president, but the EC conducts the procedure to elect the head of State.

Announcing the election schedule, Election Commission Secretariat



Senior Secretary Akhtar Ahmed said that voting will be held on August 20 from 2.00 pm to 5.00 pm at the Jatiya Sangsad (National Parliament) session hall.

Nomination papers will be accepted at the office of the Chief Election Commissioner on August 13.

The scrutiny of nomination papers will be held on August 16. The last date for withdrawal of can-

didature is August 18. The lawmakers would cast votes to elect the new president inside Parliament on August 20. However, no voting will be held in case of a consensus candidate.

According to the State-run BSS news agency, Ahmed told journalists that the announcement for the presidential election schedule was made after discussions with Parliament Speaker Hafiz Uddin Ahmed, who is serving as Acting President for 90 days in accordance with the Constitution. A new President must be elected within a 90-day timeframe.

Ahmed said that the voter list for the election has been prepared and other remaining administrative procedures will be completed before the election.

Shahabuddin, a 1971 Liberation War veteran and former lower judi-

ciary judge, had taken the oath in April 2023 for a five-year term.

He cited health complications as the reason for his resignation; however, it came amid speculations that Prime Minister Rahman’s government was uncomfortable with the largely titular head of state.

Some reports had claimed that Shahabuddin contacted Hasina over the phone, disappointing the ruling Bangladesh Nationalist Party’s top leadership. The former president had dismissed the reports as “baseless.” He was elected to the highest office by the previous parliament and was the only person still holding his constitutional position, long after the violent July-August 2024 student-led street protest that toppled Hasina’s Awami League Government.

Hasina fled to India and has been living there since August 5, 2024.



Taiwan’s military drills suggest deeper alignment with US

SIMINA MISTREANU ■ Taipei

Through this year’s military drills, Taiwan has chosen to emphasise its army’s and society’s flexibility and resilience as opposed to primarily putting advanced weapons on display. Experts say the exercises’ structure indicates closer ties with the US military in the face of China’s ongoing military threat.

The annual Huang Kuang drills kicked off on Wednesday and are set to extend through Aug. 14 in various locations around the island. The live-fire exercises will test the Taiwanese army’s ability to sustain 24-hour defence operations as well as counter China’s “grey-zone tactics,” which stop just short of open warfare.

China claims the self-ruled democracy as its own territory, and has not renounced the use of force to bring it under its control. Taiwan dismisses China’s claims and insists

it is a sovereign state.

The United States, while not recognising Taiwan as a country, sees all threats to the island as a matter of great concern. Washington is bound by its own laws to provide Taiwan with the means to defend itself. (AP)

Policeman shot dead, another abducted in northwest Pakistan



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Peshawar

Unidentified gunmen shot dead a policeman and abducted another in two separate incidents in the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa in northwest Pakistan, officials said Thursday.

The motive behind both the incidents that occurred late on Wednesday night could not immediately be ascertained and investigations are in progress, police said.

Constable Noor Alam, serving in the Special Branch, was shot dead by the unidentified assailants while on his way from home to duty in Bannu district.

Police said Khan used the

same route daily to reach his workplace when he came under attack near Masoomabad on the Bannu-Miranshah Road within the limits of Cantt Police Station.

Soon after, the attackers fled the scene.

Separately Constable Irfanullah, serving as a wireless operator at Shaheed Mureed Akbar Police Station, was abducted from his native village of Sheikh Awtar in Tank district while he was on leave, police said. A search operation was launched and an investigation into the incident has been initiated, District Police Officer, Tank, said adding that efforts are underway to ensure safe recovery of the abducted constable.

Heat wave puts all major Italian cities on red alert



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Rome

Italy placed all of its major cities under the highest heat alert Thursday as a blistering heat wave gripped Europe, setting a national temperature record in Austria, fueling wildfires in France and disrupting energy and transport systems across the continent. The extreme weather has pushed temperatures above 40 degrees Celsius (104 Fahrenheit) in several countries, prompting health warnings for millions of people. Across Europe, authorities are grappling with the consequences of extreme heat: health alerts for millions

in Italy, record temperatures in Austria, drought-related disruptions to energy and shipping in Central Europe, and wildfires stretching from France to the Balkans.

Scientists and officials warn that such events are becoming more frequent and intense as the climate warms.

From the Mediterranean to Central Europe, prolonged heat, drought and wildfire conditions are increasingly becoming defining features of summer. The current heat wave has exposed vulnerabilities in public health systems, power generation and businesses to adapt to more frequent periods of extreme weather.

Sri Lanka Navy rescues 11 Indian fishermen after their boat meets with accident

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Eleven Indian fishermen were rescued by the Sri Lanka Navy on Thursday after their fishing vessel met with an accident in the island nation’s waters, according to an official statement. The accident occurred on a coastal reef off Delft Island, also known as Neduntheevu, located in the Palk Strait off the northern coast of mainland Sri Lanka.

The trawler had reportedly crossed the International Maritime Boundary Line into Sri Lankan waters late Wednesday and was allegedly engaged in bottom trawling before it ran aground, according to the Sri Lanka Navy. Sri Lanka Navy’s

spokesman Commander Chaminda Walakuluge claimed the Indian vessel was engaged in illegal fishing activities in the island’s waters and met with an accident.

In a statement, the navy confirmed that all 11 fishermen were brought ashore at Delft Island following a rescue operation.

It said the subsequent activities concerning the rescued fishermen are being jointly handled with officials from the Department of Fisheries and Aquatic Resources.

“Due to the impact of grounding on the reef, the trawler has sustained partial structural damage,” the statement said. He development comes a day after Foreign



Secretary Vikram Misri, who was here for a day-long visit, raised with Sri Lankan leaders the issues related to fishermen and requested Colombo’s cooperation for the early release of fishermen and boats detained in the island nation.

The fishermen issue is a contentious one in the ties between India and Sri Lanka, with Lankan Navy personnel even firing at Indian fishermen in the Palk Strait and seizing their boats in several alleged incidents of illegally entering Sri Lankan territorial waters.

The Palk Strait, a narrow strip of water separating Tamil Nadu from Sri Lanka, is a rich fishing ground for fishermen from both countries.

Leader of Myanmar’s military-backed Govt seeks political legitimacy in Thailand visit

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Bangkok

The head of Myanmar’s military-backed Government arrived in Thailand on Thursday for an official visit that could serve as a major stepping stone in his effort to win political legitimacy more than five years after seizing power from an elected civilian government.

President Min Aung Hlaing’s two-day visit with members of his Cabinet included meetings with Thai Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul and other officials at Government House, where several memorandums of understanding were signed covering Myanmar



migrant workers, water quality management in rivers shared by the two countries and space technology for Earth observation.

Following the meetings, the two leaders were scheduled to deliver speeches at a Thailand-Myanmar Business Forum.

At the meeting with Anutin, Min Aung Hlaing sought to reassure Thailand that his government was restoring stability and steering Myanmar toward democracy.

“Myanmar has now reestablished itself on the path to democracy and is moving toward a better future,” Min Aung Hlaing said. “As the new government, we have now begun working on national stability, peace, and national reconciliation.”

The visit has drawn criticism from activist groups such as Justice For Myanmar, which stated that the trip lends “false legitimacy” to Min Aung Hlaing and the ruling generals.

Min Aung Hlaing took a significant step toward would-be political rehabilitation in April when he was sworn in as president following an election held in phases in December and January. Critics dismissed the polls as a sham designed to consolidate the military’s grip on power while ostensibly restoring civilian rule.

The diplomatic outreach is the latest in a series of moves to re-engage with countries in the region and the international community after relations became frayed or frosty following Min Aung Hlaing’s ousting of Aung San Suu Kyi’s government in February 2021 while serving as army chief. Western governments

have shunned and sanctioned Min Aung Hlaing and his associates for overthrowing Suu Kyi’s government. Subsequent serious rights violations followed a deadly military crackdown on protests, which subsequently triggered a nationwide armed resistance movement and a bloody civil war.

The visit is among Min Aung Hlaing’s most significant diplomatic engagements and the latest in a series of trips to neighbouring countries, including China, India and Laos, as he seeks to strengthen regional ties since assuming the presidency in April.

Despite visits to those countries and close relations

with Russia, he has remained largely isolated internationally.

While he attempts to refurbish his image, Myanmar’s military continues to wage a brutal war across much of the country against pro-democracy resistance fighters and armed ethnic minority groups seeking greater autonomy.

According to the Assistance Association for Political Prisoners, an independent organisation that keeps detailed tallies of arrests and casualties linked to the civil war, more than 8,200 civilians have been killed and 31,645 arrested by Myanmar’s security forces as of Wednesday.

South Korean police raid local Starbucks headquarters



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Seoul

South Korean police raided the headquarters of Starbucks’ local operation as part of an investigation into a controversial marketing campaign that was perceived as defaming the 1980s’ pro-democracy movements.

Investigators searched the Starbucks’ headquarters in southern Seoul, police said.

Police gave no further details, but South Korean media reported investigators were also sent to the residences of Starbucks executives. The coffee chain triggered a public uproar when it attempted to promote a series of stainless-steel tumblers it called “SS Tank” by declaring May 18 to be “Tank Day.” The date marks the anniversary of a 1980 pro-democracy uprising in the southern city of Gwangju that was brutally suppressed by South Korea’s then-military-backed rulers.

The campaign also used the slogan “Thwack it on the table!” which many read as a reference to a notorious 1987 police statement that attempted to cover up the torture death of student activist Park Jong-chol.

▼PROSPECT

UPSIDA’s CEO prioritises transparency, infrastructure and industrial development

Dr Balkar Singh assumed charge as the new Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the Uttar Pradesh State Industrial Development Authority (UPSIDA) on Thursday. Soon after taking over, he chaired his first review meeting with senior officials at the Authority’s headquarters in Kanpur.

Addressing the meeting, Singh emphasised that providing prompt and transparent services to investors, strengthening industrial infrastructure, and accelerating industrial development will be the top priorities of UPSIDA.

He said, “Under the leadership of Hon’ble Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Uttar Pradesh is rapidly emerging as one of the most attractive investment destinations in the country. UPSIDA has a crucial role to play in achieving the goal of making the state a one-trillion-dollar economy, and the Authority will work with full capacity and commitment in this direction.”

In this context, Singh directed officials to ensure high-quality development and proper maintenance of all essential facilities in industrial areas. This includes roads, electricity, water supply, drainage, street lighting, sanitation, security and green development. He also stressed the need for effective implementation of UPSIDA’s key focus areas.

The CEO called for delivering time-bound and transparent services to investors through a single-window system, and for strengthening and modernising the existing industrial infrastructure. He asked officials to expedite the development of new industrial areas and industrial parks, and to ensure swift disposal of investment proposals and pending projects. Singh further directed the expansion of digital governance and technology-driven services across the Authority. He underlined the importance of developing clean, safe and green industrial areas, and promoting balanced industrial development with a strong focus on employment generation. He also asked officials to make special efforts to attract investments in high-potential sectors such as electronics, semiconductors, data centers, defence and aerospace, electric vehicles and battery manufacturing, pharmaceuticals, food processing, logistics and textiles.



Dr Balkar Singh

Gul Panag kicks off reading campaign to revive book culture

A nationwide campaign to revive the habit of reading and promote books as a source of lifelong learning was launched on Wednesday under the banner “Let’s Bring Back the Joy of Reading.” The initiative aims to encourage people across generations to reconnect with books at a time when digital media is increasingly shaping reading habits. The campaign was launched in the presence of actor, author and social advocate Gul Panag, along with educators, authors, publishers and thought leaders, who stressed the importance of reading in fostering creativity, critical thinking and informed citizenship. Speaking at the launch, organisers said the initiative seeks to engage students, families, teachers, professionals and communities through workshops, discussions and public outreach programmes.



(PNS)

The evolution of Punjab’s railway infrastructure



RAVNEET SINGH BITTU

Railways have long been the lifeline of Punjab, connecting its farms to markets, industries to supply chains and millions of pilgrims and travellers to destinations of national importance. As mobility demands continue to grow, Indian Railways is responding with one of the most comprehensive infrastructure development programmes the state has witnessed in recent decades.

Through new rail corridors, modern station redevelopment and network augmentation, Punjab is steadily building a railway system that is faster, more efficient and better equipped to meet the aspirations of a rapidly growing economy.

The scale of investment reflects this renewed focus. The annual average railway budget allocation for Punjab has increased from ₹225 crore during 2009-14 to ₹5,673 crore in 2026-27, representing a remarkable 25-fold increase.

Complementing this enhanced financial commitment are infrastructure works worth over ₹26,000 crore, covering new railway lines,

doubling projects, station redevelopment and safety enhancement works across the state.

A major thrust of this transformation has been the completion of several capacity augmentation projects that have strengthened the state’s rail network. Notable completed works include the Rajpura-Bhatinda Doubling Project (173 km) at a cost of ₹2,459 crore, the Jalandhar-Pathankot-Jammu Tawi Doubling Project (209 km) costing ₹850 crore, Ambala-Dhapper-Chandigarh Doubling (45 km) worth ₹339 crore, Mansa-Bhatinda Doubling (49 km), Jakhal-Mansa Doubling (45 km), Amritsar-Chheharta Doubling (7 km) and several strategically important bridge and doubling works, including the Kathua-Madhampur (Punjab) section with the Ravi Bridge. Collectively, these projects have enhanced line capacity, reduced congestion and enabled smoother train operations across the region.

The momentum continues through a robust pipeline of ongoing projects that promise to reshape Punjab’s connectivity landscape. Among the most significant is the Nangal Dam-Talwara-Mukerian New Line (123 km) with an investment of ₹3,726 crore, alongside the Bhanupalli-Bilaspur-Beri New Line (63 km) valued at ₹13,770 crore, one of the largest railway

infrastructure projects in the region. Other key projects include the Qadian-Beas New Line (40 km), Ferozpur-Patti New Line (26 km), Rajpura-Mohali New Line (18 km), Rajpura Bypass Line (14 km), and doubling works on the Ludhiana-Kila Raipur and Ludhiana-Mullanpur sections. These projects are expected to improve regional accessibility, strengthen freight movement and create new growth corridors across Punjab.

Infrastructure expansion has also translated into measurable achievements across the railway network. Since 2014, approximately 400 kilometres of new railway tracks have been constructed, Punjab has achieved 100 per cent broad-gauge railway electrification, and over 400 flyovers and underpasses have been built to improve safety and operational efficiency.

Simultaneously, 30 railway stations are being redeveloped under the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme, creating modern, accessible and passenger-centric transport hubs that complement the State’s expanding rail network. Moreover, Punjab is now served by Vande Bharat Express and Amrit Bharat Express train services, bringing faster, more comfortable and technologically advanced rail travel to the State.

The impact of these infrastructure projects extends far beyond the

railway network, touching almost every sector of Punjab’s economy.

As one of India’s leading agricultural states, Punjab depends on an efficient transport network to move food grains, fruits, vegetables and other agricultural produce swiftly to markets across the country. Enhanced railway capacity, additional lines and doubling projects enable faster freight movement, reduce transit bottlenecks and improve supply chain efficiency, ensuring that agricultural and industrial goods reach their destinations more reliably.

For Punjab’s manufacturing and industrial centres, including Ludhiana, Jalandhar, Mohali and Bathinda, strengthened rail connectivity supports the seamless movement of raw materials and finished products. Reduced congestion enhances operational efficiency, lowers transportation costs and improves the competitiveness of industries that contribute significantly to the state’s economy.

Improved rail infrastructure also strengthens connectivity with ports and major consumption centres, providing a vital boost to trade and logistics. Better connectivity also encourages balanced regional development by bringing smaller towns and emerging urban centres closer to economic opportunities.

Punjab’s tourism and pilgrimage

sector is another major beneficiary. The state’s railway network serves as the primary gateway to some of India’s most revered spiritual and cultural destinations, including the Sri Harmandir Sahib (Golden Temple) in Amritsar, Anandpur Sahib, Durgiana Temple, Jallianwala Bagh, Wagah Border, Takhat Sri Damdama Sahib, Gobindgarh Fort, and the Sheesh Mahal in Patiala. Improved rail infrastructure makes these destinations more accessible, enriching the travel experience for millions of domestic and international visitors each year while generating greater demand for local hospitality, transport, handicrafts and other tourism-related services.

As Punjab advances towards a more connected and competitive future, its railway network is evolving into far more than a mode of transport. It is emerging as an enabler of economic resilience, social mobility and sustainable growth. Through sustained investment, strategic infrastructure development and a vision aligned with the state’s aspirations, Indian Railways is ensuring that Punjab’s rail network remains a powerful driver of prosperity for generations to come.

The author is former union minister of state railway and food processing industries

CM Himanta launches application distribution for Nijut Moina and Nijut Babu scheme

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday launched the distribution of application forms for the Mukhya Mantrir Nijut Monia Scheme and Mukhya Mantrir Nijut Babu Scheme at a central programme held at Srimanta Sankardeva Kalakshetra.

At the same programme, the Chief Minister also disbursed ₹15.86 crore via DBT to 793 flood-affected schools across Sivasagar, Charaideo, Jorhat and Golaghat and launched financial assistance of over ₹4.26 crore from the CMRF for 21,025 students in Sivasagar and Charaideo to purchase educational materials after the recent floods. Of the amount, ₹11.00 crore have been allocated to 550 schools of Sivasagar, ₹2.22 crore to 111 schools, ₹2.06 crore to 103 schools of Jorhat and ₹0.58 crore to 29 schools of Golaghat district.

Speaking on the occasion, Sarma said, “Nijut Moina and Nijut Babu schemes are built to encourage serious learning and



academic commitment. Our goal is for these students to become role models who inspire others to study hard and aim high.”

He moreover said that the primary objective behind launching the Mukhya Mantrir Nijut Moina Scheme is to eradicate child marriage and that this remains the Government’s foremost priority. He also noted that since child marriage is not an issue affecting boys in the same way, the assistance under the Mukhya Mantrir Nijut Babu Scheme has been kept comparatively lower.

Sarma said that the Nijut Moina Scheme was introduced with the objective of covering 10 lakh girl students across the State. During 2024-25, 1.60 lakh

girls benefited from the scheme. Following its expansion in 2025-26, the number of beneficiaries increased to four lakh. During the current financial year, an additional one lakh girls are expected to be brought under the scheme.

He further said that the Nijut Babu Scheme, which benefited 50,000 boys last year, will include an additional 70,000 students this year, taking the total number of beneficiaries to 1.20 lakh. He also announced that girl students pursuing Polytechnic courses and those studying in the seventh semester of integrated postgraduate programmes would also be eligible for financial assistance under the Nijut Moina Scheme from this year.

InspeCity Space Laboratories appoints Rajeev Gambhir as executive vice president

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

InspeCity Space Laboratories, an Indian space technology company headquartered in Thane in the Mumbai Metropolitan Region, has appointed Rajeev Gambhir as its Executive Vice President, marking a significant step in the company’s next phase of growth as India’s commercial space sector expands beyond launch capabilities to advanced in-orbit technologies.



The company is developing a vertically integrated technology stack that includes Rendezvous and Proximity Operations (RPO), green satellite propulsion and robotic systems aimed at extending satellite life, reducing replacement costs and mitigating orbital debris. These technologies are expected to play a key role in enabling sustainable commercial and strategic space operations. Over the past few years, InspeCity has strengthened its capabilities in in-space operations, securing multiple contracts under the Government of India’s iDEX programme while expanding its engineering expertise and infrastructure.

DAILY SUDOKU

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

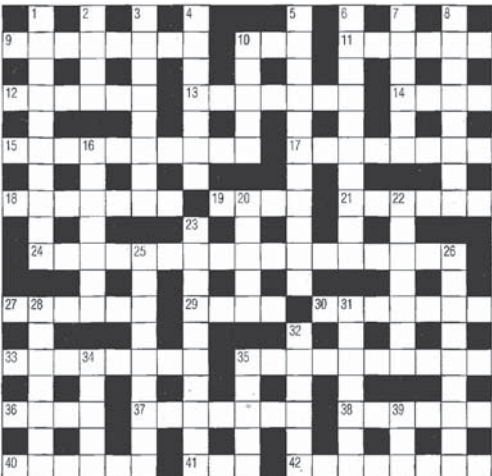


SOLUTION (6.8.26)

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8	9	5	2	7	4	6	1	3
6	2	9	7	1	3	4	8	5
3	5	7	4	2	8	1	9	6
1	4	8	6	5	9	2	3	7
5	7	2	1	3	6	9	4	8
4	1	6	9	8	7	3	5	2
9	8	3	5	4	2	7	6	1

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DOUBLE CROSSWORD FRIDAY | AUGUST 7, 2026



ACROSS
9 Think it’s in the main true, but garbled
10 To love excessively (3)
11 Do the man in - a writer (6)
12 Stress it runs in the family (6)
13 Nonsense! The twit must relinquish it and go off (7)
14 A belt is something you wear (4)
15 Not inclined to be honest (2,3,5)
17 No reaction from the gagged and blindfolded person? (3,1,4)
18 Show the harbour has fish (7)
19 Either sell, or give, the cat to (4)
21 Cheered when it tried to get rid of its rider (6)
24 You’ll be sorry when it comes! (3,3,2,9)

DOWN

1 Inconveniencing by extinguishing (7,3)
2 Grasping we’ve upset the well-known singer (4)
3 Taking mother along, I go off to get a plant (8)
4 Uneasy as ever about its being returned
5 Still remaining in force when detaining the righteous (7,4)
6 You can take it it’s satisfactory (10)
7 When the idiot stands a drink, don’t accept it (4,2)
8 Such evidence as it is that there’s building going on? (8)
10 Follow, when he leaves the bar (5)
16 Most keen to play with the tots (7)
20 Don’t take, when you hand down to (5)

27 Excellent advice - the best (6)
29 Would one be a cross between various kinds of goat? (4)
30 Is acting in, it seems (7)
33 How the confounded light is going on and off? (8)
35 The one with the nest in which there were chicks? (6,4)
36 Pound, at first, on the table (4)
37 Loving having a room, for a change, to ourselves (7)
38 Call out “Mum! There’s a child outside”
40 Disclose, about meat (6)
41 Catch and stuff (3)
42 Aim to annoy, which does make things dicey (8)

22 Not harsh with him (7)
23 Calling on one and changing one’s mind about? (6,5)
25 That can be put on if it’s fitting (10)
26 Having made a profit from, transferred to (6,4)
28 Like the invitation that came when you had flu? (3-5)
31 Its purpose is defensive, the palace aide said (8)
32 It’s probably hearts she breaks! (7)
34 Point at which the anaesthetic gets you under (6)
35 Audacity that’s just a facade? (5)
39 From a large number, might a quarter get through? (4)

SOLUTION (6.8.26)

ACROSS	DOWN
4. Audits	21. Pretender
8. Confetti	1. Sock-t
10. Tommy	2. Gnome
13. Flag	3. Very
14. Tree	4. A-isle
15. Pier	5. D-rag
16. Fax	6. Tritan
17. Thin	9. Pa-rade
19. A-V-on	11. Orb
	12. Me-tre
	13. Fine day
	15. Pit
	16. For

Invitation For Bids (IFB)

The Chief Executive Officer (CEO), Assam Skill University Project (ASUP) under Assam Skill University (ASU) ("the Purchaser) invites online bids from eligible bidders for **the below mentioned packages** at Assam Skill University:

#	Package No.	Package Name	Date of Publication		Deadline for Submission	
			Date	Time	Date	Time
1	GS02/ASU/SUY/060	Lot 2- GIS and Remote Sensing Lab	07 August 2026	10:00 Hours (IST)	07 September 2026	14:00 Hours (IST)
2	CW07	Design, Build, Supply, Installation, Testing, Commissioning and Operation Support of the Vertical Transportation (Vertical Mobility) Training Laboratory at Assam Skill University, Mangaldai, Darrang District, Assam	07 August 2026	10:00 Hours (IST)	07 September 2026	14:00 Hours (IST)

Interested bidders may download and submit their bids electronically using the e-Procurement portal <https://assamtenders.gov.in/>.

DIPR/CF/PIO/1145/7-Aug-26

Sd/-
CEO, ASUP cum Registrar, ASU

GURU NANAK DEV UNIVERSITY, AMRITSAR SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE

Short Term E-Tenders are invited for the purchase of XYZ Piezo Nanopositioner with Controller, Honeycomb Tabletop with Passive Vibrational Isolation, Single Photon Detection Module, 980 nm Diode Laser System, 532 nm DPSS Laser System and 785 nm Diode Laser be submitted online latest by **21/08/2026 upto 4:00 p.m.** Detailed information can be obtained from website www.eproc.punjab.gov.in. Any corrigendum/Addendum related to these e-tender will be uploaded, if required, on Punjab Govt. website: www.eproc.punjab.gov.in

Director of Research

2426/12/2026-27/13978 Dated CHD - 06/08/2026

Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar Advertisement No. 10/2026

Online applications are invited for the various Teaching posts in the University. Online registration of application for these posts will start w.e.f. **07.08.2026 and end on 01.09.2026**. Last Date for submitting Hard Copy of the Online submitted application is **11.09.2026**. For further details visit University Website: <http://www.digital.gndu.ac.in>.

Amritsar
06.08.2026

REGISTRAR

2426/12/2026-27/13996 Dated CHD - 06/08/2026



कार्यालय उज्जैन नगर पालिक निगम, उज्जैन छत्रपति शिवाजी भवन आगर रोड उज्जैन (Online) निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

विज्ञापन क्र./शि.वि./2026/ 1310

निम्नांकित कार्य के लिए प्रयत्न 'अ' (फर्म ए) में प्रतिष्ठित कम या अधिक के आधार पर प्रमुख अभियंता लोक निर्माण विभाग म.प्र. शासन भोपाल के कार्यालय में पंजीकृत टेन्डरर्स से उक्त विभाग में पंजीयन प्रमाण पत्र को प्रमाणित प्रति प्रस्तुत करने पर ऑनलाईन (Online) निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है, तथा टेन्डर को (श्रेणी सी) एम.पी. गवर्मेन्ट व नगरीय प्रशासन एवं विकास विभाग म.प्र. भोपाल UADD SOR 02-08-2021 सिरियल क्र. 01 का टेन्डर फर्म मूल्य 2000 एवं 02 का टेन्डर फर्म का मूल्य 12500 रहेगा। सिरियल क्र. 01 से 02 को ऑनलाईन क्रय करने व ऑनलाईन ई.एम.डी. यश एवम् समस्त दस्तावेजों को Submission करने की अंतिम दिनांक 31.08.2026 समय 17.30 रहेगा। विस्तृत निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना एवं अन्य जानकारी वेबसाइट www.mptenders.gov.in पर देखी जा सकती है। यदि उपरोक्त निविदा में किसी प्रकार का संशोधन होता है तो इसकी सूचना ऑन लाईन की जावेगी। पृथक से समाचार पत्रों में प्रकाशित नहीं की जावेगी।

क्र	टेन्डर क्रमांक	कार्य का नाम	अनुमानित लागत	अंमैरुम्पनी क्र.	समय अवधि
1	2	3	4	5	6
1	12026_UAD_526093_1	क्षीरसागर कुंड पर आवश्यक संस्थापन कार्य।	17,45,599/-	13,100/-	90 दिन
2	22026_UAD_526077_1	मालीपुरा शांति कॉम्प्लेक्स निर्माण कार्य झोन क्र.03, वार्ड क्र. 28	1,44,79,855/-	72,500/-	270 दिवस

क्रमांक:- 1311

प्रतिलिपि:-

01. मा. महापौर जी की ओर निज सचिव के माध्यम से अवलोकनार्थ प्रेषित।

उज्जैन दिनांक :- 3/8/26

उज्जैन नगर पालिक निगम में पंजीयन प्रमाण पत्र को प्रमाणित प्रति प्रस्तुत करने पर ऑनलाईन (Online) निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है, तथा टेन्डर को (श्रेणी सी) एम.पी. गवर्मेन्ट व नगरीय प्रशासन एवं विकास विभाग म.प्र. भोपाल UADD SOR 02-08-2021 सिरियल क्र. 01 का टेन्डर फर्म मूल्य 2000 एवं 02 का टेन्डर फर्म का मूल्य 12500 रहेगा। सिरियल क्र. 01 से 02 को ऑनलाईन क्रय करने व ऑनलाईन ई.एम.डी. यश एवम् समस्त दस्तावेजों को Submission करने की अंतिम दिनांक 31.08.2026 समय 17.30 रहेगा। विस्तृत निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना एवं अन्य जानकारी वेबसाइट www.mptenders.gov.in पर देखी जा सकती है। यदि उपरोक्त निविदा में किसी प्रकार का संशोधन होता है तो इसकी सूचना ऑन लाईन की जावेगी। पृथक से समाचार पत्रों में प्रकाशित नहीं की जावेगी।

क्र	टेन्डर क्रमांक	कार्य का नाम	अनुमानित लागत	अंमैरुम्पनी क्र.	समय अवधि
1	2	3	4	5	6
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क्रमांक:- 1311

प्रतिलिपि:-

01. मा. महापौर जी की ओर निज सचिव के माध्यम से अवलोकनार्थ प्रेषित।

BRIEFLY

Esports: India receive direct entry into MOBA Legends



India have received a direct invitation to the MOBA Legends: 5v5 tournament at the Esports Nations Cup (ENC) after accumulating 2,600 points in the ENC Rankings. India's roster for the tournament has Gaithanlung Gonmei (Kyle), Susanta Biswas (Kimyy), Abhijeet Katkar (Asuna), Rithik Sohal (Romcom), Evancius A. Sangma (Vann), along with reserve players Mohammad Saad (Apex) and Jay Mehta. Steve Vitug (Dale) will be India's coach, announced the Esports Foundation through a release on Thursday. The Legends competition will feature 32 teams competing for a prize pool of more than ₹14.2 crore from November 23 to 29 in Riyadh. The Esports Foundation has allocated 16 direct invitations through the ENC Rankings, and 14 places will be decided through regional online qualifiers, scheduled for August 15 to 16. The final two slots will be filled through wildcard invitations.

"One of the biggest strengths of this roster is the variety of experience each player brings. Every player has something unique to offer, whether it's leadership, mechanics, or decision-making."Our focus is to combine those strengths into a cohesive team with a clear identity and style of play. I am confident we'll be ready to take on the challenge in Riyadh," said coach Vitug. (PTI)

NWSL will start season earlier in 2027 amid Women's WC



The National Women's Soccer League will kick off its season earlier than ever before next year to work around the Women's World Cup in Brazil. NWSL Commissioner Jessica Berman gave a wide-ranging midseason State of the League address Wednesday during which she discussed next season's schedule, the impact of the men's World Cup and other topics impacting the league.

The league's 15th season will open on Feb. 11, more than a month earlier than this season. The annual Challenge Cup match will be played on Feb. 6. The NWSL will pause from June 24 to July 25 during the Women's World Cup as many of the league's players will be on national teams that qualify for the tournament. The playoffs will start on Nov. 5 and the league championship will be played on Nov. 20.

"We know that major tournaments inspire millions of people to follow the sport, and our schedule allows us to be part of the lead-in and the lead-out of that big moment," Berman said. The league is intentionally launching the season during Super Bowl weekend and will be "working closely with ESPN to make sure that the NWSL is woven into the weekend stories, and we're very excited about that," Berman said. (AP)

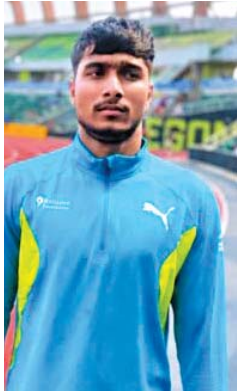
Three Indians make finals of World Athletics U20 title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Eugene (USA)

Javelin throwers Ashish Yadav and T Dharanidharan along with discus thrower Amanat Kamboj qualified for the final rounds in a decent opening day performance by the Indians at the World Athletics U20 Championships here.

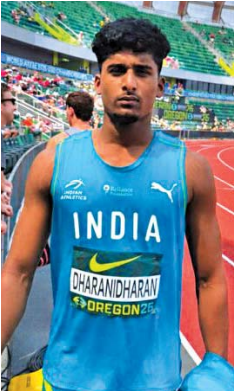
Yadav topped the men's javelin Group A qualification round with a throw of 69.87m and ended at second spot overall, behind South Africa's title favourite Jan-Hendrik Heymans who won Group B with a 76.02m throw. The 19-year-old Indian has a season's best of 74.49m, which is also his personal best.

Heymans was the lone com-



petitor to breach the automatic qualification mark of 72.50m.

Dharanidharan made it to the final round, taking the 12th and the last spot overall after finishing



fifth in Group B qualification round with a throw of 68.07m.

Those who breached the automatic qualifying mark of 72.50m or at least best 12 qualified for the final



to be held on Friday. Indian superstar Neeraj Chopra is the current world record holder in the event with his 86.48m throw in the 2016 edition of the championships in Bydgoszcz, Poland.

In women's discus throw, Amanat produced a season's best throw of 52.58m to finish sixth in Group A qualification round and take the 12th and last available spot to sneak into the finals.

China's Su Yixin took the top position across the two qualification groups with 58.06m, while compatriot Ma Chenyi was second with 57.72m.

Those who breached the automatic qualifying mark of 55m or the best 12 performers qualified for the final to be held later tonight.

Newcastle confirms hiring of Matthias Jaissle as coach to replace Eddie Howe

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ La Manga (Spain)

Newcastle confirmed the hiring of 38-year-old Matthias Jaissle as coach to replace Eddie Howe, who stepped down after nearly five years in charge.

Jaissle will immediately take charge of the Magpies in Spain at their preseason training camp, which concludes Saturday with a friendly match against Valencia at Mestalla Stadium.

"My teams are built on togetherness, hard work, intensity and a passion to improve every single day," said Jaissle, who signed a four-year contract in becoming Newcastle's first-ever German manager. Jaissle led Saudi club Al-Ahli to back-to-back Asian Champions League Elite titles. He



joined Al-Ahli in 2023 after leading Salzburg to consecutive Austrian league titles. Newcastle opens its Premier League season on Sunday, Aug. 23 at home against Liverpool.

Since Jaissle was still under contract at Al-Ahli, Newcastle had to pay a reported \$12 million

release clause.

Howe, who confirmed last Friday that he stepped down, twice led Saudi-backed Newcastle to Champions League qualification and won the English League Cup in 2025 to end the club's 70-year wait for a major domestic trophy.



Messi scores as Inter Miami beats San Luis

ALANIS THAMES ■ Miami

Lionel Messi scored his first two goals since the World Cup and took the career scoring lead in the Leagues Cup as Inter Miami overcame an early deficit to beat Atletico San Luis 4-2 on a rainy night.

The match at Nu Stadium was delayed 30 minutes in the second half because of lightning in the area.

Messi scored in the 11th and the 44th minutes. He has 14 goals in 12 Leagues Cup matches - one ahead of Los Angeles FC's Denis Bouanga for most in the tournament's four-year history.

Telasco Segovia and defender Micael also scored, and Noah Allen had three assists as Inter Miami extended its unbeaten streak to eight matches.

Messi returned to Miami's starting lineup in his second match since the World Cup, where he led Argentina to its second straight final appearance before La Albiceleste lost 1-0 to Spain. The 39-year-old played 37 minutes as a substitute in a 2-2 draw with the Columbus Crew on Saturday.

After being held off the scoresheet



against Columbus, it didn't take Messi long to make an impact on Wednesday. He fired a long cross from Allen past Andres Sanchez to equalize after David Rodriguez put San Luis ahead with a header four minutes into the match. Messi finished from close range later in the first half and assisted on Micael's header in stoppage

time. Rafa Llorente also scored for San Luis.

Messi led Miami to the Leagues Cup title in 2023 shortly after his arrival with the club. Inter Miami reached the final again last year, losing 3-0 to Seattle in a match that ended with a brawl involving Luis Suarez. The veteran forward appeared to spit

toward a member of the Sounders' staff and grabbed at least one Seattle player by the neck during the melee, resulting in a six-match tournament suspension. That means Suarez, who has seven goals in the past four matches, was not available on Wednesday and will not play in this year's tournament. (AP)

IGI Stadium completely renovated, Delhi ready to host best-ever world championships: BAI

HARDIK SHARMA ■ New Delhi

After drawing criticism over the state of facilities during the India Open earlier this year, the Badminton Association of India (BAI) on Thursday said the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium has undergone a complete renovation and is ready to host the "best-ever" edition of the BWF World Championships.

The India Open came under scrutiny after players raised concerns over the condition of the venue, including its cleanliness, training facilities and air quality. The tournament also witnessed unusual disruptions, with matches briefly halted due to bird droppings and even a monkey entering the spectator stands.

The controversy erupted after



Danish shuttler Mia Blichfeldt criticised the condition of the warm-up and practice areas at the K.D. Jadhav Indoor Hall and the Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium during the India Open, drawing attention to the poor state of the facilities.

"We've worked on every issue that came up then, and I'm happy to say those problems have been resolved completely. I'm confident this will be one of the best World Championships ever," BAI secretary general Sanjay Mishra said on the sidelines of the draw

ceremony for the World Championships.

"I would especially like to thank the Sports Ministry and SAI because they've worked very hard. Under the guidance of our president, Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma, all the preparations are progressing well," he added.

Mishra said the India Open had served as a "test event" ahead of the World Championships, helping the organisers identify shortcomings and address them well in advance.

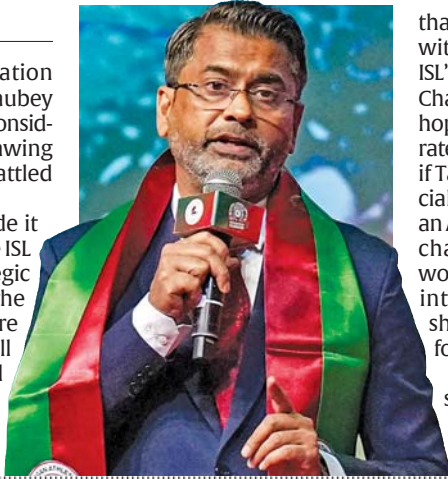
"The stadium is almost ready for the tournament. The India Open was essentially a test event for the World Championships. If we hadn't conducted that test event, we wouldn't have known what difficulties we were likely to face," he said. (PTI)

Please reconsider JFC's ISL withdrawal: AIFF chief Chaubey

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

All India Football Federation (AIFF) President Kalyan Chaubey has urged Tata group to reconsider its decision of withdrawing Jamshedpur FC from embattled Indian Super League (ISL).

The Tata group has made it clear that JFC's exit from the ISL was a long-planned strategic decision to ensure that the company returns to its core ideal of grassroots football development. Tata Steel vice President (Corporate Services) D B Sundara Ramam has also insisted



that the move has nothing to do with uncertainty surrounding ISL's commercial future. However, Chaubey said AIFF would still hope for rethink by legacy corporate house. "AIFF would be happy if Tata remains in football, especially in senior top tier football. If an AIFF request or application can change their mind...the AIFF would like to appeal that for the interest of the players, Tata should remain in the senior football league," Chaubey said.

"The AIFF welcomes any suggestion and is ready to incorporate the suggestions to ensure the best outcome,"

he said. Tata Steel has assured that Jamshedpur FC will honour all existing player contracts and help footballers find new clubs. The AIFF president said he has faith in Tata group and its decisions cannot be driven by commercial interests.

"It's all about, I think, some decision in the boardroom. And I'm sure there are reasons, but it cannot be for ₹1.1 crore participation fee or management fee. It is not that. When the board decided to withdraw the senior team from the top-tier league, I am sure they had a reason for taking this harsh decision," he said. (PTI)

Khaidem Chanu to lead India women's hockey team in Junior Asia Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Mid-fielder Khaidem Shileima Chanu will lead an 18-member Indian junior women's team in the Junior Asia Cup, scheduled to be held in Moqi, China, from August 30 to September 13.

As part of its preparations for the continental tournament, an extended squad recently returned from an exposure tour of the United Kingdom.

The match schedule and



pool compositions for the Asia Cup will be announced closer to the start of the tournament.

"I am proud of the commitment and determination these young players have shown in

earning their place in the squad for the Junior Asia Cup," said coach Tim White, who took charge of team earlier this year.

"Over the past few months, they have worked tirelessly to improve every aspect of their game, and I have seen them grow both as individuals and as a team," added White.

Infantino gets support at crisis meeting to remain FIFA president

JAMES ROBSON ■ New York

FIFA said it had apologised for errors made over Gianni Infantino's failed plan to sell stakes in the World Cup and that senior staff in attendance at a crisis meeting in Morocco "reaffirmed their full support" for his presidency.

World soccer's governing body attempted to present a unified front amid the turbulence caused by Infantino's controversial plans, with calls for him to step down. In a statement, FIFA said Secretary General Mattias Grafstrom and members of the management board in attendance in Rabat had given their support to the embattled president.

Referring to the plans to sell profits in the World Cup through a commercial subsidiary called FIFA Forward Enterprise (FFE), the



statement said "mistakes made were acknowledged" and that the "process should have been handled differently."

FIFA said a letter had been sent to FIFA Council and member associations apologizing for errors and committed to "ensure they do not happen again."

Grafstrom's stated support was

notable after he distanced himself from Infantino's now abandoned plans in an email to all FIFA staff calling the last week a "sad and reproachable series of events." FIFA said Infantino had also reaffirmed his support for his secretary general.

World soccer's governing said the FFE proposal was "now off the

table." "There are always lessons to be learned, and FIFA will continue to improve its processes in light of this experience," it said. It remains to be seen if the meeting will ease pressure on Infantino.

Serious questions Earlier Wednesday, the association of European soccer leagues - including the Premier League, La Liga and Serie A - called for governance reform of FIFA. It described the FFE proposal as "dangerous" and said it pointed to deeper concerns about how the governing body operates. It said it raised "serious questions about FIFA's governance, internal culture and decision-making."

"Now more than ever, FIFA requires governance reform that ensures that all relevant stakeholders have a formal role in decisions that shape the future of our game." (AP)



Indian batters aim to ace spin test before Test against SL

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Indian batters will be keen to fine-tune their skills against spin during a three-day warm-up match against a local Sri Lanka XI at the Nondescripts Cricket Club here on Friday as they gear up for a two-match Test series against the Islanders next week.

Quality spin proved to be India's Achilles Heel against New Zealand and South Africa at home recently, and the challenge will not be any different against Sri Lanka.

The Islanders have a capable unit of tweekers, particularly in home conditions, and thus this warm-up match assumes massive importance for Indian batters ahead of the first Test at Galle on August 15.

Some frontline batters like skipper Shubman Gill, KL Rahul and Yashasvi Jaiswal had started preparations against spin individually at their home facilities before



boarding the flight to Colombo, but that cannot really supplant an outing on a Sri Lankan pitch.

The three-day match will give them valuable first-hand idea about local conditions, and it is important because many of them are playing the red-ball format for the first time on these shores.

India's last Test series in Sri Lanka was in 2017, and the team composition has undergone vast changes in the last decade.

In fact, only Rahul, Kuldeep Yadav and Ravindra Jadeja in this squad have appeared in Test matches in Sri Lanka.

In the absence of an injured Jasprit Bumrah, pacer Mohammed Siraj will be India's bowling lead with

support coming from Prasidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Manav Suthar and Saransh Jain.

This largely inexperienced bowling lineup, except Siraj and Kuldeep, will be eager to bowl on a Lankan pitch once again.

Both Brar and Jain had very good outings for India A against Sri Lanka A last month at Galle, and they will be raring to have another round of practice under their belt.

Head Coach Gautam Gambhir emphasised on this point.

"We know what is in front of us. We can do volume, we can push our limits, we can tick all the boxes and come 15th morning whether we are batting first or bowling first we will be absolutely ready with every answer to every question thrown at us. "So make sure to tick all the boxes from now on," Gambhir exhorted his wards in a video posted by BCCI.

However, intermittent rain is predicted to lash the city from Friday and that may jeopardise India's designs.

Meanwhile, Sri Lanka also announced a strong SLC XI that contained some fron-

trunners to make it to the Test squad.

Led by Sonal Dinusha, who has played three Tests for SL, the squad features pacers Vishwa Fernando, Lahiru Kumara and spinners Isitha Wijesundara and Ramesh Mendis.

Teams (from)

India: Shubman Gill (Captain), KL Rahul (Vice-Captain), Yashasvi Jaiswal, Rishabh Pant (WK), Sai Sudharsan*, Dhruv Jurel (WK), Ravindra Jadeja, Kuldeep Yadav, Manav Suthar, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Devdutt Padikkal, Saransh Jain, Aaquib Nabi.

SLC XI: Nishan Madushka, Ravindu Rathantha, Pasindu Sooriyabandara, Pavan Rathnayake, Ahan Wickrama singhe, Sonal Dinusha (Captain), Anjala Bandara (wk), Nipun Dananjaya, Lahiru Kumara, Vishwa Fernando, Asanka Manoj, Isitha Wijesundara, Ramesh Mendis, Kesara Nuwantha, Dilum Sudeera.



Come 15th, we will be ready with all the answers: Gambhir

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Their home Test run in recent past may not have been particularly impressive but India head coach Gautam Gambhir has asserted that his team will be ready with all the answers when the two-Test series against Sri Lanka gets underway here from August 15. In an address to team before a practice session in Colombo, Gambhir also welcomed new entrants—spin-bowling all-rounder Saransh Jain and pacer Aaquib Nabi.

"We know what's in front of us, we know what we are playing for. We can do the volume, we can push our limits, we can tick all the boxes," Gambhir said in the video shared by BCCI on social media.

"Come 15th morning, whether we are batting first, whether we are bowling first, we're absolutely ready with every answer, every question that's thrown at us, and every answer we are ready to give. So make sure we tick all the boxes from now on," he added.

The first match of the series will be played in Galle from August 15 while the second game will be held here from August 23. It would be India's first ICC World Test Championship assignment since the disastrous 0-2 home defeat to South Africa in



December last year.

Saransh has been picked in the squad on the basis of his consistently fine run for Madhya Pradesh in the domestic circuit. Nabi is in to replace an injured Jasprit Bumrah. He played a stellar role in J&K's maiden title-winning run in Ranji Trophy last season. "We've got a couple of new guys in. To start with, Saransh, congratulations. You've worked extremely hard to be here," Gambhir said.

England recall Lawrence, Carse, Pope, Cook for Pakistan Tests, Bethell ruled out

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

Dan Lawrence was recalled by England after two years on Thursday to play in the first test against Pakistan and Jacob Bethell was ruled out of the three-match series by a right knee injury. The post-Ben Stokes era starts in Leeds on Aug. 19 and Surrey batting allrounder Lawrence will have the first crack at trying to fill the prodigious shoes of the former test captain.

He is set to bat at No. 6 with wicketkeeper Jamie Smith likely to slot in one place lower down, while Bethell being sidelined has opened door for Jordan Cox at first drop in batting order.

Cox's own injury misfortune meant he made his test debut only in June against New Zealand at The Oval, where he was down at No. 7.

Fast bowler Brydon Carse missed the 2-1 loss against the Black Caps



because of an injury to his right hand but he was named in England's 16-man squad for the first two tests under returning captain Joe Root, with Marcus Trescothick interim coach in the absence of the newly appointed

Stephen Fleming.

Former vice-captain Ollie Pope was back after being discarded during the Ashes series in Australia where he averaged 20.83 before making way for Bethell. Seamer Sam Cook was also in, after his lone test appearance against Zimbabwe in May 2025. Off-spinner Shoab Bashir was retained although it remained to be seen if he keeps his spot in XI after confirmation that Lawrence, who bowls off-spin, will definitely be in team.

Pakistan beat West Indies to end 8-match overseas losing streak in Tests

FREDRICK MZWILI
■ Port of Spain (Trinidad)

Pakistan ended its eight-match losing streak away from home in cricket Tests with a resounding eight-wicket victory over the West Indies on Wednesday to level the series. First innings century-maker Abdullah Shafique and Babar Azam, in his first series since being reappointed as captain, reappointed as captain, led Pakistan to 77-2 with unbeaten knocks of 24 runs each as the visitors achieved victory shortly after lunch on Day 4 of the second test.

Babar knocked off the target by hitting back-to-back sixes against left-arm spinner Jomel Warrican, whose six-wicket haul in the first innings had limited Pakistan's lead to 43 runs.

West Indies won the first test by 90 runs at Tarouba. In the second test, spinners Sajid Khan and Ali Usman utilized favorable



conditions on a wearing wicket of Queen's Park Oval to ensure Pakistan remained unbeaten in a

test series against the West Indies since 2000. Pakistan lost the

wickets of Imam-ul-Haq, brilliantly snapped up by Justin Greaves in the slips cordon for 9 in Jayden Seales' first over Wednesday, and Azan Awaiz was bowled by Shamar Joseph for 18 before Shafique and Babar sealed the win inside four days. Earlier, West Indies had set up a modest target of 75 runs after it got bowled out for 117 with off-break bowler Sajid (4-32) and left-arm spinner Usman (4-39) sharing eight wickets between them.

Opening batter Brandon King couldn't bat in West Indies' second innings due to a back injury sustained on Day 3 when he ran out Babar with a direct throw from short cover.

Resuming on 106-3 - only 60 runs ahead - the resistance of West Indies' tailenders ended quickly with Usman picking up the wickets of Kemar Roach and Joseph. Greaves, the last recognized batter, played on to seamer Mohammad Ali's delivery back onto his stumps after adding just two runs to his total as he attempted a cross batted shot, but got a big inside edge.

Pakistan's last test win away from home came against Sri Lanka in 2023 during Babar's first tenure as captain, before Shan Masood led the side for nearly three years during which Pakistan lost 3-0 in Australia; 2-0 in South Africa; and 2-0 in Bangladesh. Masood was eventually relieved of the captaincy after Pakistan's dismal run in red-ball cricket, but the return of Babar as skipper saw Pakistan losing the first test at Tarouba last week for Pakistan's eighth loss away from home in three years. (AP)

Senior national shooting coach under SAI scrutiny for conflict of interest; NRAI denies allegations

AJAI MASAND ■ New Delhi

A top national shotgun coach, who is part of India's preparations for the upcoming Asian Games, is under scrutiny following allegations of a conflict of interest over the award of a contract to build a shooting range in Chennai. A senior Sports Authority of India (SAI) official has "been asked to examine" the matter. The senior coach works with the National Rifle Association of India (NRAI) to train India's top shotgun shooters for international competitions, including the Olympics, ISSF World Cups, World Championships, and National Championships. "A complaint has been received in the head office of the Sports Authority of India and we have asked the stadia division and the regional



director of Delhi to examine it. However, no report has come to me so far," said a senior SAI official.

"I don't remember the name of the complainant but that complainant has put his name. It (com-

plaint) is by name, it is not an anonymous complaint. So, therefore, since it's not an anonymous complaint, it will be looked into as per the government procedures," the SAI official added. (PTI)

Memphis playoff event won't be part of top tier in PGA Tour in 2028

DOUG FERGUSON ■ New York

The PGA Tour confirmed Wednesday the FedEx St Jude Championship, the leadoff post-season event since 2022, would not be part of the top-tier Championship Series in 2028.

After more than a week of piecemeal announcements which tournaments would be part of Championship Series, the tour said Memphis, Tennessee, would not be on the list. That also raises questions about the future of the FedEx Cup - the name and structure - when the overhaul begins in 2028.

Memphis has hosted a PGA Tour event since 1958. It was given World Golf Championship status in 2019 when the tour lost sponsorship at Firestone Country Club, and it became a playoff



event in 2022 when another sponsor did not renew.

The tournament still is under consideration for a Challenger Series event, one of about 20 tournaments that will serve as a feeder tour to the more lucrative

Championship Series.

"As we prepare for the FedEx St Jude Championship next week and again in 2027, we remain in close conversation about the future of our partnership," the tour said in a statement. "We are

grateful to FedEx for all it contributes to the sport, and the positive impact they make in the community, including in Memphis with St. Jude. "As we implement a new competitive model and map out our schedule for 2028 and beyond, we believe Memphis is well-positioned to remain part of the PGA Tour."

The Commercial Appeal and Sports Business Journal first reported Memphis would not be part of the upper tier in 2028.

The tournament is held at TPC Southwind, where holes are lined by homes on a course that typically delivers exciting finishes. Justin Rose won last year in a playoff over J.J. Spaun. But attendance has been sparse in the August heat, particularly during the weekday rounds. (AP)